Representation Without Integration: Black Mayors and Residential Sorting

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Abstract

I study how minority political representation shapes residential mobility and racial sorting. Using individual-level voter registration records, I track migration into and out of North Carolina neighborhoods around mayoral elections, and extend the analysis to 120 U.S. cities. Electing a Black mayor raises population most in majority-Black neighborhoods: 6.2% in North Carolina, 7.3% nationally. The flows show the gain comes from retention of Black and white residents, not arrivals. Yet Black growth concentrates in majority-Black neighborhoods, which raises city-level segregation. Black representation can thus produce spatially targeted retention shared by both groups while inducing racially asymmetric sorting.

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1 Introduction

Who benefits from political representation when residents can vote with their feet? Studies of political representation typically estimate how elected officials change outcomes for a fixed constituency (Chattopadhyay and Duflo, 2004; Ferreira and Gyourko, 2009, 2014), and work on minority representation asks whether minority officeholders improve outcomes for co-racial constituents or narrow gaps between minority and majority groups (Hopkins and McCabe, 2012; Nye, Rainer, and Stratmann, 2015; Logan, 2020; Sylvera, 2021; Beach et al., 2024; Sakong, 2026). Yet much of what a city government does—infrastructure, zoning, permitting, redevelopment—is attached to places rather than to people. When the policy instrument is spatial and households are mobile, the population that receives the policy is itself endogenous. The constituency years after an election may differ from the one that elected the official. The incidence of representation then depends not only on how officials allocate resources, but on how residents re-sort in response.

This re-sorting matters most when the two groups respond differently. An improvement in a neighborhood can raise retention among everyone who lives there and still increase citywide segregation, if one group responds more strongly in the places where it is already concentrated. It can also attract newcomers who displace existing residents, and that path raises segregation too when those who leave move to neighborhoods where their own group is already concentrated. Local incidence and citywide sorting are distinct objects that need not move together. The two paths are also hard to tell apart, since a neighborhood whose population rises because affluent newcomers arrive looks the same in a population count as one whose population rises because existing residents stop leaving. Distinguishing them requires observing micro-level migration flows, which little existing work has done, because most settings offer aggregate counts.

I study these responses in the context of Black mayoral elections in U.S. cities. Mayors influence neighborhood conditions through capital spending, appointments, zoning, permitting, and redevelopment. At the same time, racial disparities in neighborhood conditions have persisted despite the expansion of Black municipal representation. To recover the underlying migration flows, I construct individual-level records from North Carolina voter registration files. North Carolina is well suited to the question because it is one of the few states to combine repeated snapshots of the same registered voters with detailed local-election records. Unique voter identifiers, recorded race, and residential addresses let me follow each voter's annual moves across neighborhoods and cities and separate new arrivals from the retention of existing residents. I combine these records with closely contested mayoral elections between Black and white candidates and estimate a stacked difference-in-differences design, comparing cities where the Black candidate narrowly wins with cities where the Black candidate narrowly loses over the four years before and after each election. Restricting attention to close elections narrows the differences between winning and losing cities, and event-study estimates show no differential pre-trends before the election. I then extend the population and sorting analysis to 120 major U.S. cities using annual census-tract data.

The results come in two parts. The first part concerns what happens *within* neighborhoods. Electing a Black mayor raises neighborhood population, and the largest gains are in majority-Black neighborhoods. In North Carolina cities, a narrow Black victory raises net population by 3.8% across all tracts and by 6.2% in majority-Black tracts. The U.S. major-city sample shows the same concentration: population in majority-Black neighborhoods rises by 7.3% after a Black victory, and the increase there mainly comes from Black residents.

These gains come from retention rather than new arrivals. In majority-Black neighborhoods, inflows do not change significantly, while out-migration falls by 4.8%. The decline is shared across racial groups: Black out-migration falls by 44.1 voters per tract and white out-migration by 26.8, equivalent to 3.8% and 7.1% of the Black and white populations resident in these tracts. Moves out of the city account for about 61% of that decline, so the response is not a reshuffling of residents within the city. The increase in majority-Black neighborhoods therefore does not resemble displacement. Existing residents of both races become less likely to leave.

The second part examines what happens *across* neighborhoods. Using a pooled specification based on within-city comparisons, I estimate differential effects by neighborhood type. The population response is racially asymmetric: in neighborhoods with a low Black population share, nearly all of the population growth comes from white residents. The pattern reverses as a neighborhood's Black share rises: Black gains grow and white gains shrink, so the two groups move toward different parts of the city. Composition shifts as a result: relative to low-Black-share tracts, the Black population share rises by an additional 1.8 percentage points in majority-Black tracts in North Carolina and 2.7 percentage points nationally. School enrollment moves the same way, with Black enrollment rising in schools in majority-Black neighborhoods, so the reallocation involves households with children and not only the registered adults in the voter file. The shift raises segregation: the city-level Black–white dissimilarity index increases by 1% in North Carolina and 2.4% across major cities. What raises it is not white flight. White out-migration from majority-Black neighborhoods falls rather than rises in North Carolina, and nationally the white population of those neighborhoods holds steady.

A final set of results asks what changed on the ground. Housing prices rise by about 5.8% in majority-Black neighborhoods, against 2.2% in neighborhoods with smaller Black populations. The growth in the number of polluting facilities observed in low-Black-share neighborhoods is largely absent in majority-Black ones, a more favorable relative change in the distribution of an environmental disamenity. Local newspaper coverage shifts toward Black neighborhoods, while arrests and reported city-level crime do not change. Greater retention therefore coincides with higher relative market valuation, more favorable land-use outcomes, and greater public attention.

These findings make several contributions. Most directly, the paper brings a migration perspective to the study of minority political representation, which has focused on policy, employment, and capitalization outcomes (Hopkins and McCabe, 2012; Nye, Rainer, and Stratmann, 2015; Logan, 2020; Sylvera, 2021; Beach et al., 2024; Sakong, 2026). When policies are attached to places and households can move, the direct incidence of representation and its longer-run sorting effects need not coincide, so the consequences of group-responsive government cannot be evaluated through group-specific outcomes alone. The flow data separate two things a population count runs together. The flows also supply the quantity response beneath the price response that prior work observes (Beach et al., 2024): prices rise and existing residents stay, which points to stronger demand from existing residents rather than an influx of newcomers. And because residents react to permitting, enforcement, service quality, and public attention all at once, where they choose to live summarizes neighborhood changes that are hard to measure one at a time. More broadly, the results connect representation to work showing that the effect of a policy depends on the sorting responses it induces (Arcidiacono and Lovenheim, 2016; Ellison and Pathak, 2021; Harjunen, Saarimaa, and Tukiainen, 2023).

The paper also contributes to research on place-based policy and residential segregation. Models of endogenous sorting predict that improvements in minority neighborhoods can raise segregation (Banzhaf and Walsh, 2013; Bayer, Fang, and McMillan, 2014); I provide direct migration evidence that this occurs, and show that the mechanism is not white flight. White residents become less likely to leave majority-Black neighborhoods; segregation rises because the Black response is larger where Black residents are already concentrated. This distinguishes the sorting documented here from tipping dynamics (Card, Mas, and Rothstein, 2008) and places it within the broader lesson that household mobility reallocates the benefits of place-based policy (Kline and Moretti, 2014; Busso, Gregory, and Kline, 2013; Diamond, 2016).

The findings further speak to work on Black suburbanization and central-city demographic change (Boustan, 2010; Bartik and Mast, 2022; Baum-Snow and Hartley, 2020). That literature attributes the decline of Black populations in central-city neighborhoods to relative amenities and housing costs; I identify local political representation as a force operating on the opposite margin—whether existing residents remain in urban neighborhoods and cities.

Finally, the paper contributes to research on environmental justice, which has emphasized federal regulation, information disclosure, and remediation (Banzhaf, Ma, and Timmins, 2019; Currie et al., 2015; Christensen, Sarmiento-Barbieri, and Timmins, 2022; Currie and Walker, 2019; Sager and Singer, 2022). The results show that under a Black mayor the number of polluting facilities grows less in majority-Black neighborhoods than in comparable white neighborhoods, a relative change in the neighborhood distribution of an environmental disamenity. Because facility siting and residential sorting are jointly determined (Depro, Timmins, and O'Neil, 2015), I read this as a co-movement consistent with the migration response rather than as an independently identified effect.

The remainder of the paper is organized as follows. Section 2 describes the institutional role of mayors in U.S. cities. Sections 3 and 4 present the data and empirical design. Section 5 reports the effects on population change and migration flows. Section 6 turns to racial sorting, neighborhood composition, and segregation. Section 7 examines neighborhood amenities and related outcomes. Section 8 presents robustness tests, and Section 9 concludes.

2 Institutional background

Municipal governments can shape neighborhood conditions through public spending, capital planning, land-use regulation, permitting, and economic-development policy. Mayors often propose municipal budgets and capital-improvement plans, negotiate their approval with city councils, and oversee or appoint officials in departments responsible for public works, planning, housing, code enforcement, and economic development. These powers give mayors scope to influence where cities invest in roads, sidewalks, parks, utilities, sanitation, public spaces, housing, and other neighborhood infrastructure.

Mayors may also affect private development. City governments approve zoning changes, redevelopment plans, conditional-use permits, and development agreements, and may provide tax incentives, grants, or infrastructure support for selected projects. Mayors can shape these decisions by setting policy priorities, negotiating with council members, appointing members of planning and development bodies, and coordinating city agencies. For example, a mayor may support mixed-use or residential redevelopment in one neighborhood, prioritize infrastructure needed for new investment, or use tax-increment financing and related redevelopment tools where authorized by state law. These decisions can change both neighborhood amenities and private demand for particular locations.

Local political leadership can also influence the distribution of environmental disamenities. Federal and state agencies generally regulate emissions and administer environmental standards, but municipal governments retain important authority over land use. Zoning maps determine where industrial activities are permitted, while conditional-use permits, site-plan approval, buffering requirements, infrastructure provision, and code enforcement can affect whether a facility locates or expands in a particular neighborhood. City governments may also influence the redevelopment of industrial land and the placement of new manufacturing or waste-related activities. Thus, mayors do not directly determine the emissions reported to the Toxics Release Inventory, but they can influence the relative siting and expansion of TRI facilities across neighborhoods.

The formal authority of mayors varies across municipal institutions. Under a mayor–council system, the mayor generally has greater control over budget proposals, administrative appointments, and executive decisions. Under a council–manager system, day-to-day administration is delegated to a professional city manager and the mayor's formal executive authority is more limited. Even in these systems, however, mayors may preside over council meetings, participate in council votes, make or influence appointments, set the public agenda, and build coalitions around spending and development priorities. In North Carolina, municipal structure varies with city size, but approximately 80% of the cities in the analysis sample operate under a mayor–council form of government (Lineberry, Edwards, and Wattenberg, 1983; Svara, 2003; Upshaw, 2014).

The relevant question is therefore not whether a mayor controls every neighborhood decision unilaterally. Rather, it is whether a change in political leadership can alter the priorities, coordination, and implementation of municipal policy. Electing a Black mayor may affect neighborhood conditions through changes in capital spending, administrative appointments, zoning and permitting decisions, redevelopment policy, enforcement, or public attention. The empirical estimates should consequently be interpreted as the reduced-form effect of electing a Black rather than a white candidate in a close mayoral election, operating through the broader institutions of local government.

3 Data

3.1 North Carolina voter registration and migration records

I construct individual-level migration records from repeated snapshots of the North Carolina voter registration file maintained by the North Carolina State Board of Elections, and use them to build an annual voter panel running from 2009 through 2020.[1] Each record contains a unique voter identifier, registration status, recorded race, gender, age, party affiliation, and residential address. The identifier allows me to follow the same voter across years and locations within the state. I geocode each residential address and assign it to a census tract and block group.

The migration measures come from comparing each voter's location across consecutive annual observations. A voter who changes census tracts contributes one outflow to the origin tract and one inflow to the destination tract; a voter whose tract does not change is counted as remaining in place. I aggregate these transitions to the tract-year level and define net registered-voter population change as inflows minus outflows. Addresses also let me separate moves within a city from moves that cross city and county boundaries, which is what the cross-boundary results in Section 5.2 use.

Recorded race is grouped into five mutually exclusive categories: white, Black, American Indian or Alaska Native, Asian, and Hispanic. Every outcome for all residents aggregates the five, while the tables report the Black and white series separately, so a coefficient for all residents need not equal the sum of its Black and white counterparts. A voter's first and last appearances in the file require separate treatment, since neither need represent a move. I therefore exclude the first observed registration of voters younger than 20 and the final observed registration of voters older than 75.[2]

Two checks speak to how well the file captures migration. Table 1 compares its tract-level demographic composition with 2019–2020 Census population estimates for North Carolina residents ages 20 to 75: the voter data show slightly higher Black and white population shares and a somewhat higher female-to-male ratio. Table A.1 summarizes the moves themselves, and most of them cross municipal lines. About 75% of moves into a block group originate outside the municipality and 64% outside the county, while 69% of moves out have destinations outside the municipality and 54% outside the county. Figure A.1 then compares county-level inflows and outflows in the voter data with county migration measures the Internal Revenue Service constructs from annual changes in tax-return addresses. The two sources line up closely for both flows, which indicates that the voter records track broader

[1]The snapshots are available from 2005 onward and contain records for active voters, inactive voters, and voters removed from the registration rolls within the previous decade. The state produces multiple snapshots each year, including files near the beginning of the year and around Election Day. Additional institutional detail on registration and list maintenance appears in the Appendix.

[2]North Carolina permits preregistration at ages 16 and 17, so a first registration near voting age may be recorded as an inflow when no move occurred. Disappearance from the file at older ages may likewise reflect death rather than migration. I retain voters observed in at least three annual snapshots; roughly 25% of them appear in all 12 years and the rest in between three and eleven. Section 8.3 reports a stricter alternative that drops the first and final record of every voter regardless of age, and the results are similar.

geographic migration patterns.

3.2 North Carolina mayoral elections

I obtain North Carolina mayoral election data from the State Board of Elections, combining election returns, candidate filing records, and voter registration information. Few states provide both historical voter registration snapshots and detailed local election records. Returns identify the office contested, candidate names, and vote totals for elections from 2009 through 2019, but generally do not report candidate race, gender, or party affiliation. I therefore match candidates to the voter registration file by name and municipality, resolving ambiguous matches with the residential addresses in candidate filing records.[3]

Panel A of Table 2 summarizes the full set of North Carolina mayoral candidates. Black candidates account for 15.5% of the sample and women for 24.8%. Among Black candidates, 58.9% are Democrats and 35.7% nonpartisan, with the remainder split between Republican and unaffiliated. Among white candidates, 22.8% are Democrats, 45.6% nonpartisan, and 10.9% Republicans. Table A.3 reports characteristics of the candidates in the Black–white election sample used in the analysis.

3.3 Major U.S. cities

To see whether the North Carolina population patterns generalize, I collect mayoral election data for the core cities of the 120 largest U.S. Metropolitan Statistical Areas, covering 1999 through 2019. Results and candidate characteristics come from Our Campaigns, Ballotpedia, official election records, local-government pages, campaign materials, and local newspaper coverage.[4] Panel B of Table 2 summarizes this candidate sample: 21% of candidates are Black and 19.1% are women.[5]

I combine these elections with annual census-tract population estimates from the Census for 2006 through 2019, restricted to residents ages 20 through 75 so that the national sample matches the age range of the North Carolina voter data.[6] These data report annual tract

[3]Some candidates cannot be matched because names are recorded differently across sources ("John Smith" versus "J. Brady Smith" or "John B. Smith"). For these I collect demographic and political information by hand from official local-government pages, campaign materials, local newspaper coverage, Our Campaigns, and Ballotpedia (https://www.ourcampaigns.com; https://ballotpedia.org). In races with more than two candidates I retain the top two vote recipients in the decisive round.

[4]Where a candidate's race is not reported explicitly, I code it from the available biographical and photographic evidence.

[5]Among Black candidates, 76.1% are Democrats and 8.1% Republicans, with the remainder nonpartisan or unaffiliated. Among white candidates, 47.4% are Democrats, 29.7% Republicans, and 12.9% nonpartisan.

[6]https://seer.cancer.gov/censustract-pops/. Population is reported for the same five racial and ethnic categories used in the North Carolina data

populations by race but do not follow individuals over time. The national analysis therefore measures changes in population stocks and racial composition, and cannot separate inflows from outflows, which is the distinction the North Carolina panel is built to recover. Table 1 presents summary statistics for the national tract sample.

3.4 Analysis samples

The North Carolina election sample contains mayoral contests from 2009 through 2019 in which the top two candidates are one Black and one white candidate. I identify 216 such elections in 122 municipalities, 55 of them in 48 municipalities decided by fewer than 10 percentage points. After merging the election and migration data the sample contains 180 elections in 108 municipalities, of which 45 close elections in 39 municipalities enter the baseline. The major-city sample contains 177 Black–white mayoral elections in 70 cities between 1999 and 2019, and the 13-percentage-point bandwidth selected in Section 4.2 yields 52 of them for the main population specifications. Table A.3 reports candidate characteristics for both final samples.

For each election I construct an event-specific panel covering the four years before and the four years after, omitting the election year itself because inauguration dates differ across cities and because policy and administrative changes may begin before the term does (McCrary, 2002; Baicker and Jacobson, 2007).

I classify census tracts by their racial composition in the 2010 Census. Majority-Black tracts have a Black population share of at least 50%, diverse tracts a share of at least 30% but below 50%, and lower-Black-share tracts a share below 30%. The three categories are mutually exclusive and exhaustive, so every tract enters one of them. I place the two thresholds at 50% and 30% for concrete reasons. Fifty percent defines a majority-Black neighborhood, the object of most policy and legal discussion of minority representation. Thirty percent sits just above the average tract Black share in both samples, 24.1% in the North Carolina voter data and 25.8% in the major-city data (Table 1), so the diverse category collects neighborhoods around or somewhat above the citywide average without being majority Black, and the lower-Black-share category collects those where Black residents are underrepresented. For the racial-sorting comparisons in Figures 1(b), 2(b), and 3, I separately define majority-white tracts as those with a white population share of at least 50%.

Table A.2 compares pre-election city characteristics by the race of the winning candidate in the full election sample. North Carolina cities electing Black mayors are larger on average than those electing white mayors, with mean populations of roughly 43,734 and 27,385, and have a slightly higher Black population share, 36.9% against 32.9%. In the major-city sample average total population and Black population share are similar across the two groups. Balance tests for the close-election samples that identify the effects appear in Section 8.1.

3.5 Neighborhood amenities and related outcomes

Several additional datasets support the analysis of neighborhood conditions in Section 7. The North Carolina analyses use tract-level house prices, block-group TRI facilities, public school enrollment, and city-level crime and arrest data. The major-city analysis uses neighborhood-level newspaper coverage.

Housing prices. I use the tract-level House Price Index from the Federal Housing Finance Agency for 2000 through 2018.[7]

Toxics Release Inventory facilities. Facility-level data come from the U.S. Environmental Protection Agency's Toxics Release Inventory, which records the location and reported chemical releases of facilities in covered industries. TRI facilities are commonly used to study the location of environmental disamenities and environmental inequality (Banzhaf and Walsh, 2008; Wang et al., 2021). I geocode each facility to a census block group and construct two annual outcomes: an indicator for whether the block group contains at least one facility, and the number of facilities it contains. In 2015 roughly 13% of North Carolina block groups contain at least one. These measures capture where facilities are sited rather than ambient pollution, toxicity, or individual exposure. Figure A.2 shows that both outcomes rise with a block group's Black population share in the cross-section.

Public school enrollment and crime. School data come from the Common Core of Data through the Education Data Portal and cover approximately 2,600 North Carolina K–12 public schools observed between 2004 and 2019. I assign each school to the census tract in which it is located and examine total, Black, and white enrollment.[8] City-level arrest and reported-crime data come from the Federal Bureau of Investigation's Uniform Crime Reports, and cover total arrests per capita, arrests by race, the Black share of arrests, and

[7] The FHFA index measures changes in single-family home values with a weighted repeat-sales method. I drop observations below the 1st and above the 99th percentile of the HPI distribution. Table A.4 reports summary statistics for the full sample and separately for lower-Black-share, diverse, and majority-Black tracts.

[8] About 30% of schools are majority Black by student enrollment, and 14% are located in majority-Black tracts. Table A.5 summarizes enrollment and demographics.

reported crimes per capita. Both datasets serve as external checks on the migration response rather than as outcomes mayors control directly.

Local newspaper coverage. The media analysis uses major U.S. cities, since digitized local newspaper archives are thin for the smaller North Carolina municipalities. I collect newspaper pages published between 2000 and 2019 from Newspapers.com and NewsBank and search for pages mentioning both a neighborhood name and its city. Neighborhood names and boundaries come from municipal planning and development departments; of the 39 cities with elections inside the 13-percentage-point bandwidth, 32 have usable boundary data.[9] From these pages I construct an indicator for any coverage, page-count measures of coverage frequency, and each neighborhood's share of total citywide neighborhood coverage. Because fewer than 20 majority-Black neighborhoods appear in close-election cities, the baseline media analysis defines a Black neighborhood as one with a Black population share above 30%. The median Black share in this sample is 15.6%, and the results hold as that threshold varies between 30% and 40%.

4 Empirical strategy

4.1 Stacked difference-in-differences specification

This paper applies a stacked difference-in-differences approach to compare neighborhood outcomes before and after mayoral elections contested between a Black and a white candidate, in cities where the Black candidate wins relative to cities where the Black candidate loses. Because elections occur at different times and treatment effects may evolve over a mayoral term, conventional two-way fixed effects estimators can place negative weight on some comparisons (Goodman-Bacon, 2021; Baker, Larcker, and Wang, 2022); the stacked estimator of Cengiz et al. (2019) avoids this by isolating clean comparisons within each election. The estimating equation is

$$\text{Outcome}_{bct} = \beta_1 \left(\text{Blackwin}_c \times \text{Post}_t\right) + \beta_2 \text{Post}_t + \theta_c + \eta_b + \tau_t + \varepsilon_{bct}, \tag{1}$$

where b indexes neighborhoods, c indexes elections, and t indexes years measured relative to the election. The dependent variable Outcome_{bct} is the population or migration outcome in neighborhood b of the city holding election c in year t. Blackwin_c is an indicator equal to

[9] I overlay these boundaries with Census blocks and allocate block-level population to neighborhoods in proportion to the share of each block's area falling inside the neighborhood, which assumes population is distributed uniformly within a block. Table A.6 reports summary statistics for the media sample.

one if the Black candidate wins election c, and Post_t is an indicator equal to one in the years following the election. Their interaction, $\text{Blackwin}_c \times \text{Post}_t$, switches on only for treated cities in the post-election period. The coefficient β_1 is the parameter of interest: the differential change in the outcome after a narrow Black victory relative to a narrow Black defeat.[10] I include municipality-election fixed effects θ_c, neighborhood fixed effects η_b, and year fixed effects τ_t. ε_{bct} is the error term, and standard errors are clustered at the city level.

For each election, I construct a separate panel spanning the four years before and after the election, containing the treated city together with control cities observed over the same window; the election year is omitted because inauguration dates differ across cities (McCrary, 2002; Baicker and Jacobson, 2007). Controls are restricted to cities that are neither currently governed by a Black mayor nor elect one before the window closes, and the panels are stacked and estimated jointly with panel-specific fixed effects.

Identification rests on parallel trends: conditional on the fixed effects, neighborhood outcomes in cities where the Black candidate wins would have followed the same path as in cities where the Black candidate loses. What the design requires, then, is that the two groups of cities were on comparable trajectories before the election, a condition I assess directly in Section 4.3.

4.2 Restricting to competitive elections

Cities that elect Black mayors might differ systematically from those that do not. Table A.2 shows that, in the unrestricted sample, North Carolina cities electing Black mayors are larger and have higher Black population shares, so comparing the full set of cities would confound the effect of representation with the characteristics that produce it. I therefore restrict the sample to contests in which the two candidates finish within a narrow margin, so that treated and comparison cities resemble one another. This restriction makes the parallel-trends assumption more plausible.

To ensure that the margin is not chosen in a way that favors particular results, I collapse the data to one observation per city, measure post- versus pre-election changes in the residualized outcome, and apply the bandwidth selector of Calonico, Cattaneo, and Titiunik (2014).[11] I compute the selected window separately for total, Black, and white net population change and average the three, so that a single sample is used throughout the paper. This procedure yields a window of 10 percentage points in North Carolina and 13 in the major-city

[10]The level term Blackwin_c enters only through this interaction. On its own it does not vary over time within a neighborhood and is therefore collinear with the neighborhood fixed effects η_b.

[11]I specify a degree-zero polynomial to match a difference-in-differences design that compares pre- and post-election averages.

sample, or 45 elections in 39 North Carolina municipalities and 52 elections nationally.

Because the width of the window trades comparability against precision, I do not rely on the selected value alone but report estimates from 6 to 14 percentage points in Table A.17, discussed in Section 8.5. The estimates are stable across that range. Total net population stays between roughly 57 and 70 voters per tract from 8 to 14 points, with variation across windows small relative to the confidence intervals. At 6 points only 29 elections remain and the estimate falls to 40.22 voters, still significant at the 1% level.

4.3 Evidence on the identifying assumption

The design does not require the unobserved determinants of neighborhood population to be uncorrelated with a Black candidate's victory. By comparing changes before and after each election, it accounts for fixed differences between the two groups of cities and requires only that their outcomes would have trended similarly absent the election. I provide three pieces of evidence in support of this condition.

First, I report all main results as event studies spanning the four years preceding each election (Figures 1–4). The pre-election coefficients are the natural place to look for diverging trajectories between treated and comparison cities. They sit close to zero in the North Carolina sample and the national sample, with no systematic trend in either.

Second, I test for pre-election differences between the two groups of cities within the competitive-election sample. Table A.10 compares total population, Black population, their logarithms, and the Black population share, and finds no statistically significant differences between cities in which a Black candidate narrowly wins and those in which one narrowly loses, in either sample. Tables A.11 and A.12 extend the comparison to the outcome variables themselves, using only pre-election observations. In North Carolina, pre-election net population change is statistically indistinguishable for the pooled sample and for majority-Black tracts, the two central outcomes of the analysis. In the major-city sample two differences are significant: total population across all tracts is marginally higher where the Black candidate narrowly wins, and the Black population in majority-Black tracts is lower there. Both are differences in pre-election levels, which the tract fixed effects in equation (1) absorb, and the second runs against the post-election finding of concentrated Black population growth in those tracts. Section 8.1 discusses these tests in detail.

Third, I address the most natural competing explanation for a change in mayoral race: a simultaneous change in partisan control, which characterizes 14.8% of the North Carolina contests between Black and white candidates. If party rather than race were driving the results, controlling for a Democratic victory should attenuate the estimates, and close elections decided on party alone should reproduce them. Neither holds. Section 8.2 shows that including Post × Demwin leaves the Black-mayor coefficients essentially unchanged, while a separate sample of close elections between Democratic and non-Democratic candidates does not reproduce the neighborhood- and race-specific migration pattern documented here. Democratic victories generate less than a third of the total population response and essentially none of it in neighborhoods with Black population shares above 30%. Appendix Table A.13 reports the exercise directly and shows that replacing Blackwin with Demwin produces no comparable concentration of Black population growth in majority-Black neighborhoods, so the racial-sorting response is not replicated by Democratic victories.

Lastly, the migration measure itself could pick up registration artifacts rather than moves. A first registration near voting age may enter as an inflow, and removal from the rolls after a death may enter as an outflow. The baseline sample therefore drops initial registrations for voters younger than 20 and final registrations for voters older than 75. Section 8.3 goes further and drops the first and final record of every voter regardless of age. Because that rule also removes genuine interstate migrants, the estimates fall by roughly a quarter, but the neighborhood pattern is unchanged and the effect remains significant in majority-Black and low-Black-share tracts alike. Public school enrollment offers a check from outside the registration system. It records where children actually attend school, so it cannot be produced by changes in registration behavior, and it shows the same spatial pattern: relative to schools in low-Black-share neighborhoods, Black enrollment rises in schools located in majority-Black neighborhoods, while the white differential is small and insignificant (Table A.8).

4.4 Heterogeneity across neighborhoods

Equation (1) estimated separately by neighborhood type gives category-specific effects but does not test whether they differ. I therefore estimate

$$\begin{aligned}\text{Outcome}_{bct} = \beta_1 (\text{Blackwin}_c \times \text{Post}_t) + \beta_2 (\text{Blackwin}_c \times \text{Post}_t \times \text{Diverse}_b) \\ + \beta_3 (\text{Blackwin}_c \times \text{Post}_t \times \text{MajorBlack}_b) + \gamma' \mathbf{Z}_{bt} + \theta_c + \eta_b + \tau_t + \varepsilon_{bct}, \quad (2)\end{aligned}$$

where Diverse_b and MajorBlack_b indicate Black shares of 30–50% and at least 50%, and $\mathbf{Z}_{bt}$ contains the lower-order Post×type interactions. Tracts below 30% are omitted, so β_1 is their effect and β_2 and β_3 are differences relative to them. As in equation (1), θ_c absorbs election fixed effects, η_b absorbs neighborhood fixed effects, and τ_t absorbs year fixed effects.

5 Population growth and retention

This section and the next examine how electing a Black mayor affects neighborhood population, residential mobility, and racial sorting. Figures 1–4 report event-study estimates, and Tables 3–7 report average post-election effects. The two sections answer different questions. This section answers what happens within neighborhoods: a Black mayoral victory increases population, with the largest effects in majority-Black neighborhoods, and in North Carolina those gains come from existing residents of both races becoming less likely to leave rather than from an influx of newcomers. Section 6 turns to what happens across neighborhoods, where the two racial groups respond differently, so that the same electoral event that raises retention within majority-Black neighborhoods also raises the geographic concentration of Black residents citywide.

5.1 Net population change

Figure 1(a) reports the event-study estimates for four series: all neighborhoods, majority-Black neighborhoods, diverse neighborhoods with Black shares between 30% and 50%, and neighborhoods with Black shares below 30%. The estimates are close to zero before the election and show no differential trend. After a Black mayoral victory, net population increases in all four series. The increase is largest in majority-Black neighborhoods and continues to grow through years three and four, when it is roughly twice the estimate for neighborhoods with Black shares below 30%. Table 3 reports the average post-election effects. Across all tracts, a Black mayoral victory increases net population change by 68.06 voters per tract (s.e. 9.34, $p<0.01$), a 3.8% increase. Net Black population increases by 29.73 voters, 4.7% of the baseline mean of 636 Black voters, and net white population by 27.78 voters, 2.8% of the baseline mean of 995 white voters.[12]

The largest effect occurs in majority-Black tracts. Net population increases by 103.48 voters per tract ($p<0.01$), a 6.2% increase. Net Black population increases by 56.75 voters

[12] The total population and net-population-change measures aggregate five mutually exclusive racial and ethnic categories constructed in the preprocessing—white, Black, American Indian or Alaska Native, Asian, and Hispanic—while the tables report only the Black and white series separately. The coefficient for all residents therefore need not equal the sum of the Black and white coefficients, and the difference between them is the implied response of the three unreported categories. In the North Carolina data this residual is small and positive: about 11 voters per tract across all tracts and 16 voters in majority-Black tracts. In the national data it is larger and negative. Across all tracts in Table 5, the positive Black and white estimates imply a decline of roughly 84 residents in the remaining categories, which is why the pooled estimate for all residents is close to zero. The gap is largest in diverse tracts, where it is about 189 residents. The pooled "all residents" estimates in Table 5 should therefore be read alongside the race-specific columns rather than as their sum.

and net white population by 30.76 voters (both p<0.01), which correspond to a 4.9% increase for Black residents and an 8.1% increase for white residents, whose resident base in these tracts is much smaller. In tracts with Black population shares below 30%, net population increases by 53.92 voters (p<0.01), a 2.8% increase, but its composition differs sharply. Net white population increases by 32.27 voters (p<0.01), or 2.1%, and accounts for most of the level of the gain. The Black estimate of 9.90 voters is significant only at the 10% level; measured against a small Black base it is a 4.2% increase, so the proportional Black response in these neighborhoods is not small, but it is imprecisely estimated and contributes little in levels. Diverse tracts lie between the two. Net population also rises there, but by less in both absolute and proportional terms (30.07 voters, or 1.8%), with positive and statistically significant contributions from both racial groups.

Figure 1(b) compares Black and white voter changes in majority-Black and majority-white neighborhoods, where majority-white neighborhoods have a white population share of at least 50%. Black voter growth in majority-Black neighborhoods is the largest of the four series throughout the post-election period and much larger than Black voter growth in majority-white neighborhoods. White voter growth remains positive in majority-Black neighborhoods but is smaller, and is comparable to white growth in majority-white neighborhoods. The sorting pattern examined in Section 6 is therefore driven by the concentration of Black voter growth in majority-Black neighborhoods rather than by white flight.

The same population patterns appear in 120 major U.S. cities. Figure 2 and Table 5 report the national estimates.[13] Figure 2(a) reports the event-study estimates for all neighborhoods, majority-Black neighborhoods, diverse neighborhoods, and neighborhoods with Black shares below 30%. The pre-election coefficients are imprecise but statistically indistinguishable from zero and show no systematic trend. After a Black mayoral victory, population rises in the majority-Black series, and the increase is the largest and the most persistent of the four. Figure 2(b) shows that this increase is a Black-population phenomenon: Black population in majority-Black tracts rises sharply and continues rising through years three and four, while white population in the same tracts is flat throughout. Table 5 reports the average post-election effects. Across all tracts, the pooled estimate for total population is small and imprecise. The race-specific columns are more informative: Black population increases by 76.91 residents (p<0.10), a 7.0% increase, while the white estimate of 13.82 residents is indistinguishable from zero.[14]

The clearest effect again occurs in majority-Black tracts. Population increases by 262.40

[13] These data measure annual tract population stocks and do not separately identify migration inflows and outflows, so the retention margin analyzed in Section 5.2 cannot be isolated.

[14] As noted above, the pooled estimate is not the sum of the two, because the three unreported racial and ethnic categories decline by roughly 84 residents per tract on average.

residents per tract ($p<0.05$), a 7.3% increase. The gain is almost entirely Black: Black population rises by 251.72 residents ($p<0.01$), a 9.7% increase, while the white estimate is 0.09 residents and precisely estimated at zero. Unlike in North Carolina, then, majority-Black neighborhoods nationally do not gain white residents—but neither do they lose them, which is the relevant comparison for the white-flight interpretation considered in Section 6. In tracts with Black population shares below 30%, total population increases by 98.39 residents, a 2.1% increase, but the estimate is imprecise. Black population increases by 30.36 residents ($p<0.10$), a 7.1% increase off a small base, and white population by 73.25 residents, or 2.1%, though the white estimate is not statistically significant. The proportional Black response in these neighborhoods is thus similar to the national average, but it operates on a small base and contributes little to the level of the population change. [15] The national results thus match the North Carolina pattern in its main respect: population growth concentrates in majority-Black neighborhoods. What differs between the two samples is the composition of that growth. Majority-Black neighborhoods in North Carolina gain Black and white residents alike, whereas nationally the increase comes from Black residents.

5.2 Retention, not replacement

The population gains reported above can arise in two ways: more people move in, or fewer people move out. A single year-end head count cannot tell the two apart, yet they mean opposite things. A neighborhood that fills up with newcomers may be one whose long-standing residents are being pushed out, while a neighborhood that simply loses fewer people is one where those residents chose to stay. Census counts and the tract-level sources behind most of the related literature report only the total, and the national sample of Section 5 is no exception. The North Carolina voter records follow the same individuals from one year to the next, so arrivals and departures can be counted and tested separately. Table 4 splits tract-level net population change into migration inflows and outflows, for all voters and by race. Figure 3 traces the corresponding event-study patterns for majority-Black and majority-white neighborhoods.

Across all tracts, a Black mayoral victory raises inflows by 26.41 voters per tract ($p<0.05$), or 1.5%, and lowers outflows by 41.66 voters ($p<0.01$), or 2.4%. Out-migration is the larger margin, and also the racially broader one. Black inflows do not change significantly while white inflows rise by 12.62 ($p<0.05$), but outflows fall for both groups, by 23.08 among Black residents and 15.16 among white residents (both $p<0.01$).

[15] The estimates for diverse tracts are the least informative in the national sample. Both race-specific coefficients are positive while the pooled coefficient is negative and imprecise, a discrepancy accounted for by the unreported racial and ethnic categories, whose implied decline is largest in this category.

Retention is strongest in majority-Black neighborhoods. Total inflows there rise by 22.38 voters, an insignificant estimate, while total outflows fall by 81.10 voters (p<0.01), a 4.8% reduction. Black outflows fall by 44.08 voters (p<0.01), or 3.8%, and white outflows by 26.76 voters (p<0.01), or 7.1% of a much smaller resident white population. Neither group's inflow estimate is distinguishable from zero. In Figure 3 these outflows decline after the election and fall further in years three and four, while the inflow estimates stay smaller and less precise. In majority-white tracts, by contrast, the outflow series remains at or above zero throughout the post-election window, so the decline in departures belongs specifically to majority-Black neighborhoods even though inflows rise in both. Population growth in majority-Black neighborhoods mainly comes from existing residents of both races becoming less likely to leave.

In low-Black-share neighborhoods, residents lean on arrivals instead. Where the Black share is below 30%, inflows rise by 33.21 voters (p<0.05), driven by white inflows of 20.52 voters (p<0.05), while the Black inflow estimate is essentially zero (0.699). Outflows fall by 20.71 voters (p<0.10), about a quarter of the decline recorded in majority-Black tracts. Growth in these neighborhoods reflects new arrivals, disproportionately white, rather than the retention that dominates in majority-Black tracts. Diverse tracts follow the same pattern in weaker form, with inflows up modestly (21.26, p<0.10) and outflows statistically unchanged.

Table A.7 shows that retention operates largely at the city boundary. Across all tracts, fewer departures from the city account for most of the fall in outflows: cross-city move-outs drop by 29.07 voters (p<0.01), about 70% of the total outflow decline. The pattern is sharpest in majority-Black tracts, where cross-city move-outs fall by 49.33 voters (p<0.01), roughly 61% of the total outflow decline, with declines of 24.28 among Black and 26.81 among white residents (both p<0.01). Cross-city move-ins rise by far less (27.09, p<0.05, Black-tilted), and total inflows into these tracts are not significantly different from zero. The residents who stop leaving majority-Black neighborhoods are disproportionately those who would otherwise have left the city altogether, so the response is not a reshuffling of residents within the city.

The decomposition changes how the population gains should be read. In majority-Black neighborhoods the increase is a retention effect, shared by Black and white residents and realized mainly at the city boundary. It looks neither like displacement, where arrivals replace departing residents, nor like conventional white flight, since white out-migration falls. In lower-Black-share neighborhoods, and to a lesser degree in diverse ones, the gains rest instead on new arrivals, disproportionately white. The rise in retention for both races in the same neighborhoods points to a place-based improvement in desirability rather than to a benefit aimed at one group, an interpretation Section 7 takes up directly.

6 Racial sorting across neighborhoods

If Black and white populations grew in the same proportion in every neighborhood, neighborhood racial composition and the citywide distribution of the two groups would remain unchanged. This section shows that they do not. I first show that Black gains rise with a neighborhood's existing Black share while white gains do not, then trace the resulting change in neighborhood racial composition, and finally show that the two together raise citywide segregation.

6.1 Racially asymmetric gains and neighborhood composition

The net-population columns of Table 7 enter all neighborhood types in a single specification with common election, year, and tract fixed effects. Differences across types are therefore identified from neighborhoods observed in the same city and election.

In North Carolina, the population gain in neighborhoods with Black shares below 30% accrues almost entirely to white residents. Net white population rises by 43.68 voters per tract ($p<0.01$), a 3.0% increase, while the Black estimate is indistinguishable from zero. As a neighborhood's Black share rises, the composition of the gain reverses. Relative to the low-Black-share baseline, net Black population is 69.69 voters higher in majority-Black tracts ($p<0.01$, or 6.0% of the Black population resident in those tracts), while net white population is 37.63 voters lower ($p<0.01$). Diverse tracts sit between the two, with a Black differential of 42.60 voters ($p<0.01$) and a white differential of -21.15 ($p<0.10$). Total net population is still 44.65 voters higher in majority-Black tracts ($p<0.05$), so shifting white gains toward whiter neighborhoods does not offset the concentration of Black gains. The national sample shows the same gradient in sharper form. Relative to low-Black-share tracts, net Black population is 238.92 residents higher in majority-Black tracts ($p<0.01$, 9.2% of the Black population resident there) and total population 423.80 residents higher ($p<0.05$), while the white differential of 41.99 residents is small and insignificant. Black gains rise with a neighborhood's existing Black share and white gains do not, so a single electoral event moves the two groups toward different parts of the city.

This asymmetry changes neighborhood racial composition. Table 6 reports the effect on the Black population share by neighborhood type. In North Carolina, electing a Black mayor raises the Black share by 0.56 percentage points across all tracts, a 1.5% increase over the baseline share of 37.9% ($p<0.10$). The increase is concentrated in majority-Black neighborhoods, where the Black share rises by 1.26 percentage points ($p<0.01$), about 1.9% relative to their baseline share of 68.2%. Where the Black share is below 30% the change is small and insignificant, at 0.28 percentage points, as it is in diverse tracts. The national sample gives a stronger compositional response: the Black share rises by 0.73 percentage points across all tracts ($p<0.01$) and by 1.59 percentage points in majority-Black neighborhoods ($p<0.01$), with no detectable change where the Black share is below 30%. The diverse category carries the largest point estimate, 2.05 percentage points ($p<0.05$), on a much smaller sample. Column 4 of Table 7 confirms that the shift holds within cities: relative to low-Black-share tracts, the Black share rises differentially by 1.77 percentage points in majority-Black neighborhoods in North Carolina ($p<0.10$) and by 2.73 percentage points nationally ($p<0.01$). Black population growth is not spread evenly across space. It raises the Black share precisely where that share is already high.

6.2 Citywide segregation

These offsetting movements raise citywide segregation. The largest U.S. metropolitan areas have grown steadily less segregated since 2000, with the Black–white dissimilarity index falling by roughly 17.8% by 2020.[16] Figure 4 plots event-study estimates of the effect of electing a Black mayor on this index. The pre-election coefficients are close to zero. After a Black victory they turn positive in both samples, reaching approximately 0.006 in North Carolina and 0.011 in the major-city sample by the third and fourth years, increases of roughly 1% and 2.4% over baseline segregation. These increases are small relative to the long-run decline in segregation but still meaningful: a single mayoral term undoes roughly one to three years of progress.

The increase does not reflect white flight. Table 3 shows that the white population in North Carolina's majority-Black neighborhoods rises, and Table 4 shows that white out-migration from those neighborhoods falls.[17] In the national sample white population in

[16]The dissimilarity index quantifies the percentage of a group's population that would need to relocate across neighborhoods for each neighborhood to reflect the racial composition of the larger geographic area. The index ranges from 0.0, indicating complete integration, to 1.0, indicating complete segregation. The index is defined as

$$D = \frac{1}{2}\sum_{i=1}^{N}\left|\frac{a_i}{A} - \frac{b_i}{B}\right|,$$

where a_i is the population of Group A in area i, such as census tract i; A is the total population of Group A in the larger geographic unit, such as the city; b_i is the population of Group B in area i; and B is the total population of Group B in the larger geographic unit. In this context, Group A is the white population and Group B is the Black population. The index D measures residential segregation between Black and white residents at the city level.

[17]The positive white level effect in Table 3 and the negative white differential in Table 7 are consistent

majority-Black tracts is flat rather than falling, with an estimate of 0.09 residents and a standard error of 18.14, which rules out white departures of even modest size. Segregation rises not because white residents leave majority-Black neighborhoods, but because Black retention and population growth respond more strongly there than anywhere else in the city.

Sections 5 and 6 thus describe a single sequence. Electing a Black mayor raises neighborhood population, most strongly in majority-Black neighborhoods. In North Carolina those gains come from lower out-migration among Black and white residents alike. Across neighborhoods, though, the two groups sort in opposite directions, so the Black share rises where it is already high and citywide segregation increases. The sequence accords with models in which place-based improvements in historically disadvantaged minority neighborhoods raise their attractiveness to minority households and thereby increase segregation (Banzhaf and Walsh, 2013; Bayer, Fang, and McMillan, 2014). Black political representation improves retention for residents of both races within majority-Black neighborhoods while increasing the geographic concentration of Black residents.

7 Neighborhood amenities and related outcomes

The preceding two sections leave one question open. Within majority-Black neighborhoods, electing a Black mayor increases net population mainly by reducing out-migration, and residents of both races stay. Across neighborhoods, the gains accrue disproportionately to Black residents where the Black share is already high. Either pattern would follow from an increase in the relative attractiveness of majority-Black neighborhoods, the first because residents already there choose to remain, the second because Black households respond most strongly where they are already concentrated.

Mayors can influence neighborhood quality through public spending, infrastructure, zoning, permitting, and development policy. If the decline in out-migration reflects place-based changes, the same elections should also be followed by improvements in the relative valuation or amenity conditions of majority-Black neighborhoods. I examine two outcomes that capture different dimensions of this possibility. Housing prices provide a broad equilibrium measure of neighborhood demand and perceived quality. The distribution of Toxics Release Inventory facilities captures a concrete local disamenity that may respond to zoning and permitting decisions. Neither outcome is a component of the migration accounting identity, and together they do not constitute a formal mediation analysis. Housing prices adjust

rather than contradictory, since the two specifications answer different questions. The category-specific regressions estimate separate fixed effects within each neighborhood type, whereas the pooled specification constrains them to be common in order to identify differences across types within cities. White retention improves in majority-Black neighborhoods, but by less than in neighborhoods with few Black residents.

jointly with residential demand, and TRI facilities capture only one dimension of neighborhood quality. I read the results as complementary evidence consistent with a place-based explanation for the migration response. I then turn to local media attention and to further implications of migration and sorting.

7.1 Housing-price capitalization

House prices capitalize changes in public and private neighborhood attributes and are commonly used to measure the value of local investments (Chay and Greenstone, 2005; Turner, Haughwout, and Van Der Klaauw, 2014; Beach et al., 2024). I use the tract-level FHFA House Price Index and estimate effects on its logarithm after accounting for city-specific time trends.[18]

Column 1 of Table 8 shows that a Black mayoral victory increases housing prices by 4.1% across all tracts ($p<0.01$). Column 2 shows an increase of 2.2% in tracts with Black population shares below 30% (p-value=0.023). The increase is 3.6 percentage points larger in majority-Black neighborhoods (p-value=0.011), implying a total increase of approximately 5.8%, more than twice the response where Black residents are few. In diverse neighborhoods the differential is small and insignificant, at 0.5 percentage points (p-value=0.388). The gradient in prices follows the gradient in migration. Prices rise most in the neighborhoods with the largest decline in out-migration and the largest concentration of Black population growth. Read together with the flow decomposition in Table 4, the price increase reflects rising demand rather than a contraction of supply, since the quantity response in these neighborhoods is positive.

7.2 The relative siting of polluting facilities

Pollution exposure is an important neighborhood disamenity and affects residential location choices (Bayer et al., 2016; Banzhaf and Walsh, 2008; Gamper-Rabindran and Timmins, 2011; Depro, Timmins, and O'Neil, 2015; Hausman and Stolper, 2021). Communities of color have also historically faced greater exposure to polluting facilities. Mayors may influence the relative distribution of these facilities through zoning, land-use regulation, and conditional-use permits. I measure this environmental disamenity using the EPA's Toxics Release Inventory. Table 9 reports effects on the presence and number of TRI facilities, with block groups having Black population shares below 30% as the omitted category. Column 1 estimates an OLS model in which the outcome equals one if a neighborhood contains any

[18] The FHFA House Price Index measures changes in single-family home values using a weighted repeat-sales method. I exclude observations in the bottom and top 1% of the house-price distribution.

TRI facility. Columns 2 and 3 estimate Poisson pseudo-maximum-likelihood models for the number of TRI facilities.

Column 1 shows no detectable effect on the presence of a TRI facility. Column 2 restricts the sample to neighborhoods that already contain a TRI facility. There a Black mayoral victory increases the expected number of facilities by 23.0% in block groups with Black population shares below 30% (p-value=0.003), and the response is 15.1% lower in majority-Black neighborhoods (p-value=0.036), leaving an implied increase of approximately 4.4%. Column 3 uses all neighborhoods and shows a similar pattern: the expected number of TRI facilities increases by approximately 21.4% in block groups with Black population shares below 30% (p-value=0.020), with a response 16.7% lower in majority-Black neighborhoods (p-value=0.067) and an implied increase of approximately 1.1%.

The TRI results do not show a clear absolute decline in polluting facilities in majority-Black neighborhoods. What they show is that the increase observed in neighborhoods with smaller Black populations is largely absent there. Electing a Black mayor changes the relative distribution of this environmental disamenity and limits the growth of TRI facilities in majority-Black neighborhoods. Unlike housing prices, TRI counts are direct evidence that local land-use outcomes change alongside the migration response. Research on government efforts to reduce environmental inequities has focused primarily on Clean Air Act amendments (Currie and Walker, 2019; Sager and Singer, 2022), pollution-information disclosure (Wang et al., 2021; Banzhaf and Walsh, 2008), and federal remediation programs (Haninger, Ma, and Timmins, 2017). These findings complement that literature by showing that local political representation can also shape the neighborhood-level distribution of environmental disamenities.

The housing-price and TRI results together indicate that stronger retention in majority-Black neighborhoods coincides with higher relative market valuation and with more favorable relative treatment along a concrete neighborhood disamenity.

7.3 Local media attention

Black mayors may also affect which neighborhoods receive public attention. Local media coverage can raise the visibility of neighborhood needs and put pressure on local officials to respond. It also gives residents a forum in which to voice concerns and priorities, allowing a broader set of community perspectives to enter local decision-making (Milan, 2009). By shifting policy priorities, public communication, and the issues a city government emphasizes, Black mayors may increase the visibility of Black neighborhoods and bring their concerns into local public discussion. To examine this possibility, I collect local newspaper coverage and neighborhood-boundary data for major U.S. cities from 2000 to 2019, and compare white neighborhoods with neighborhoods in which the Black population share is at least 30%.[19]

Table 10 shows that electing a Black mayor shifts newspaper coverage toward Black neighborhoods relative to white neighborhoods. The differential estimates are positive and significant for whether a neighborhood is covered (0.081, $p<0.10$), for the frequency of coverage (0.113, $p<0.05$), and for aggregate coverage (0.155, $p<0.01$). The shift is relative rather than absolute. The level estimates for white neighborhoods are negative, with coverage of white neighborhoods falling on the extensive margin ($p<0.05$) and in the aggregate ($p<0.10$), while the implied effects for Black neighborhoods, obtained by summing the level and differential coefficients, are close to zero. The column 3 estimate implies that the coverage gap between Black and white neighborhoods narrows by approximately 17%. Column 4 shows the same reallocation in shares: Black neighborhoods gain 0.00113 of the total neighborhood coverage in their city ($p<0.10$), roughly 11% of the mean share of 0.01, while the corresponding estimate for white neighborhoods is indistinguishable from zero.

These findings offer complementary evidence that Black political representation redirects public attention toward Black neighborhoods, which may help bring neighborhood concerns into public debate and prompt later policy responses. The data do not reveal the content of coverage or establish that media attention changes residential behavior, and in the count outcomes the reallocation works largely through reduced coverage of white neighborhoods rather than increased coverage of Black ones. I therefore treat this as suggestive evidence of a possible agenda-setting channel.

7.4 Further implications of migration and sorting

The patterns established in Sections 5 and 6 also surface in outcomes beyond the voter registration data. Section 6 showed that Black population growth concentrates in majority-Black neighborhoods. If that reallocation involves households rather than only the registered adults in the voter file, it should be visible in the composition of local schools. This section explores a downstream consequence of migration and sorting. Table A.8 examines public school enrollment, which depends largely on where families live and is not directly controlled by mayors. Relative to schools in neighborhoods with Black shares below 30%, Black enrollment increases by an additional 31.95 students in schools located in majority-Black neighborhoods ($p<0.05$), about 11% of mean Black enrollment, while total enrollment is 34.25 students higher ($p<0.10$). The white differential is small, negative, and insignificant,

[19] Due to the limited sample size in the media coverage data, fewer than 20 majority-Black neighborhoods are observed in cities with close elections, making estimates for this group underpowered. I therefore compare white neighborhoods with neighborhoods in which the Black population share is at least 30%.

so Black students account for the increase in total enrollment at these schools. The racial gradient here mirrors the one in Table 7, and it indicates that the residential response extends to households with school-age children and changes the racial composition of local schools.

Section 5.2 attributed the population gains in majority-Black neighborhoods to lower out-migration, and neighborhood safety is an important determinant of residential choice (Bayer et al., 2016). Table A.9 therefore asks whether changes in public safety or policing accompany the retention response. Electing a Black mayor has no statistically significant effect on total arrests, arrests by race, the Black share of arrests, or the reported city-level crime rate. All five point estimates are small relative to their means and none approaches conventional significance. These nulls give no evidence that the decline in out-migration follows from broad citywide changes in crime or policing. They do not rule out smaller or neighborhood-specific changes in safety, which the city-level data cannot detect.

8 Robustness tests

This section takes up five concerns with the baseline estimates: pre-election differences between treated and comparison cities, confounding by mayoral party, measurement error in the migration records, the inclusion of re-elected Black mayors, and sensitivity to the close-election bandwidth. Under all five, electing a Black mayor continues to increase net population, with the largest effects in majority-Black neighborhoods.

8.1 Balance test

Table A.2 shows that cities electing Black and white mayors differ on several observable characteristics in the unrestricted sample. Those differences need not survive within the close-election sample that identifies the effect. Table A.10 tests for pre-election differences within that sample. In North Carolina, total population, Black population, their logarithms, and the Black population share are all statistically indistinguishable between cities where a Black candidate narrowly wins and cities where one narrowly loses. The Black-share difference, for instance, is 0.0587 (s.e. 0.0555, $p \approx 0.29$). The same holds in the major-city sample, where the differences in log total population, log Black population, and the Black share are 0.0149, 0.0637, and 0.0468, none of them significant.

Tables A.11 and A.12 extend the comparison to the pre-election outcomes themselves. In North Carolina, pre-election net population change is statistically indistinguishable across narrow Black and white victories both for the pooled sample (-2.30, s.e. 8.71) and for majority-Black tracts (-6.31, s.e. 9.29), the two central outcomes in Table 3, though some race-specific differences do appear in the other categories, notably for white voters where the Black share is below 30% (-11.35, $p<0.05$). Most pre-election differences in the major-city sample are imprecise. Two are not: total population across all tracts is marginally higher where the Black candidate narrowly wins (201.56, $p<0.10$), and the Black population in majority-Black tracts is lower in those same cities (-119.66, $p<0.01$). Both are differences in pre-election levels, which the tract fixed effects in Equation (1) absorb. The identifying condition concerns trends, and the second difference runs against the post-election finding of concentrated Black population growth in these tracts. Read alongside the event studies in Figures 1 and 2, these tests indicate that the post-election effects in Tables 3 and 5 are not continuations of pre-existing trends. The sorting results in Section 6 are less exposed to this concern in any case, since they are identified from neighborhoods within the same city and election.

8.2 Party affiliation

Of the North Carolina mayoral elections between Black and white candidates, 14.8% are contests between Republican and Democratic candidates. The baseline estimates could therefore capture a change in party control rather than an effect of racial representation. I address this with two exercises. The first asks whether the Black-mayor estimates survive a direct control for Democratic victories within the main close-election sample. The second uses a separate sample of close partisan elections to ask whether electing a Democratic mayor produces a comparable population response.

I begin by adding Post $\times$ Demwin to the baseline specification, where Demwin equals one when the winning candidate is a Democrat. The coefficient on Post $\times$ Blackwin then captures the effect of electing a Black mayor conditional on the change associated with Democratic control. Table A.14 shows no attenuation. Across all tracts the coefficient on Post $\times$ Blackwin is 71.64 voters, slightly larger than the 68.06 voters in the baseline reported in Table 3, with Black and white net population rising by 28.09 and 28.53 voters (both $p<0.01$). In majority-Black tracts the total effect is 94.34 voters ($p<0.01$), with increases for both Black (60.42, $p<0.05$) and white (18.41, $p<0.01$) residents. Where the Black share is below 30% it is 60.92 voters ($p<0.01$), again driven by white residents (32.66, $p<0.01$). The coefficients on Post $\times$ Demwin, by contrast, show no consistent positive pattern across neighborhoods or racial groups. Most are insignificant, and the two significant ones differ in sign: white net population in majority-Black tracts (16.54, $p<0.01$) and Black net population in diverse tracts (-12.19, $p<0.05$). The population increase associated with electing a Black mayor thus survives a direct accounting for the winner's party.

I then replace Blackwin with Demwin and reestimate on close elections between Democratic and non-Democratic candidates, to see whether Democratic control alone reproduces the neighborhood- and race-specific pattern. It does not. Appendix Table A.13 shows that a narrow Democratic victory raises net population by 20.91 voters across all tracts, less than a third of the 68.06-voter Black-mayor effect and significant only at $p<0.10$. More tellingly, Democratic victories have essentially no effect on net population where the Black share exceeds 30% (1.82, insignificant), which is exactly where the Black-mayor effect concentrates. The entire Democratic response sits in tracts with Black shares below 30%, where net population rises by 28.16 voters ($p<0.01$), driven mainly by white residents (19.42, $p<0.05$). Democratic control thus reproduces the part of the Black-mayor effect that operates in predominantly white neighborhoods, but not the concentration of gains in majority-Black neighborhoods that generates the sorting result in Section 6.

8.3 A stricter definition of migration

The baseline migration measure is built from changes in voters' registered addresses. To limit the risk that initial registrations are counted as inflows and that removals following death are counted as outflows, the baseline sample drops initial registrations for individuals younger than 20 and final registrations for individuals older than 75.

Table A.15 applies a stricter rule that drops every voter's first and final record regardless of age. Since this also removes genuine interstate migrants, the estimates fall modestly. Across all tracts the effect is 49.26 voters (s.e. 7.24, $p<0.01$), 27.6% below the baseline 68.06 but still a 2.8% increase over the mean of 1,769, with net Black and white population up 17.51 and 20.75 voters (both $p<0.01$). The neighborhood pattern holds. Net population in majority-Black tracts rises by 67.46 voters ($p<0.01$), about 4.0% of the mean, with increases of 36.10 for Black and 16.14 for white voters (both $p<0.01$). Where the Black share is below 30% it rises by 41.63 voters ($p<0.01$), about 2.2% of the mean, driven by white voters (26.63, $p<0.01$), while the Black estimate of 3.93 voters loses significance. That is the one qualitative change from the baseline, and it reinforces the sorting interpretation rather than weakening it. Diverse tracts continue to show smaller but significant gains for both groups. Dropping all first and final records attenuates the estimates without changing the pattern.

8.4 Excluding re-elected Black mayors

About 10% of elections between Black and white candidates involve an incumbent Black mayor seeking another term. Such elections may capture the cumulative effects of several years of Black leadership rather than the effect of a transition to a Black mayor, so I reestimate the baseline specification after excluding them.

Table A.16 shows an effect across all tracts of 55.23 voters (s.e. 11.01, $p<0.01$), a 3.1% increase, with net Black and white population up 23.19 and 22.95 voters (both $p<0.01$). Majority-Black tracts again show the largest effect, at 78.14 voters or 4.5% of the mean ($p<0.01$), where the Black-population estimate is 43.32 ($p<0.05$) and the white estimate 18.78 ($p<0.01$). Where the Black share is below 30%, net population rises by 47.65 voters ($p<0.01$), driven by white voters (29.45, $p<0.05$) with an insignificant Black estimate, and diverse tracts rise by 31.45 voters ($p<0.01$). The all-tract estimate falls about 19% relative to baseline and the majority-Black estimate about 24%, which is what cumulative effects under sustained Black leadership would produce. The response nonetheless persists, and remains significant for both racial groups in majority-Black neighborhoods, once attention is limited to transitions to Black leadership.

8.5 Alternative close-election bandwidths

The baseline uses a 10-percentage-point margin. Table A.17 varies it from 0.06 to 0.14. Between 0.08 and 0.14 the estimates are stable: total net population stays between roughly 57 and 70 voters, Black between 25 and 30, and white between 24 and 29, with every estimate significant at $p<0.01$. At the narrowest 0.06 margin, where only 29 close elections remain, the point estimates shrink by roughly 40% but stay precisely estimated, at 40.22 voters in total ($p<0.01$), 18.71 for Black ($p<0.01$), and 17.83 for white voters ($p<0.05$). The estimates are positive and significant at every margin considered, and the attenuation at 0.06 reflects a smaller and more narrowly selected set of identifying elections rather than a qualitative change in the result.

These tests reinforce the baseline findings. Neither pre-election imbalance nor party explains the estimates: the Black-mayor effect survives a direct control for Democratic victories and is not reproduced by Democratic victories alone. It also holds under a stricter migration definition, after excluding re-elected incumbents, and across the full range of bandwidths.

9 Conclusion and policy implications

This paper studies how Black political representation affects residential mobility, racial sorting, and segregation. Using individual-level voter registration records from North Carolina together with closely contested mayoral elections, I track migration inflows and outflows across neighborhoods and cities, and I examine whether the main population patterns extend to 120 major U.S. cities.

Electing a Black mayor increases population, and the largest effect is in majority-Black neighborhoods. Net population in North Carolina increases by 3.8% across all tracts and by 6.2% in majority-Black tracts. The corresponding national increase in majority-Black tracts is 7.3%, driven almost entirely by Black residents. The migration decomposition available in North Carolina shows that retention rather than large inflows produces the increase. Out-migration from majority-Black neighborhoods falls by 4.8%, with declines of 3.8% among Black residents and 7.1% among white residents, and neither group's inflow estimate is distinguishable from zero. Cross-city exits account for most of the decline, so the response is not simply a redistribution of residents within the city.

None of this resembles conventional white flight or a displacement process in which newcomers replace existing residents. Black and white residents alike become less likely to leave majority-Black neighborhoods, so Black political representation generates retention that is spatially targeted but racially shared. The response across neighborhoods is nevertheless racially asymmetric. Where the Black share is below 30%, the population gain accrues almost entirely to white residents and comes mainly from new arrivals. As the Black share rises, the composition of the gain reverses, and Black population growth concentrates in neighborhoods that are already majority Black. The compositional consequence is direct: relative to low-Black-share tracts, the Black population share rises differentially by 1.8 percentage points in majority-Black tracts in North Carolina and by 2.7 percentage points nationally. These movements increase the Black–white dissimilarity index by approximately 1% in North Carolina and 2.4% across major U.S. cities. Segregation rises not because majority-Black neighborhoods deteriorate or lose white residents, but because Black retention and population growth are more strongly concentrated there.

The neighborhood-outcome results fit a place-based interpretation. Housing prices increase by approximately 5.8% in majority-Black neighborhoods against 2.2% where the Black share is below 30%, and the growth in polluting facilities observed in the latter is largely absent in the former, a more favorable relative change in the distribution of an environmental disamenity. Local newspaper coverage shifts toward Black neighborhoods relative to white neighborhoods, while arrests and reported city-level crime do not change significantly. None of these outcomes identifies a formal mediation channel. What they show is that greater retention occurs alongside stronger relative neighborhood valuation, more favorable environmental treatment, and greater public attention.

Two policy implications follow. First, minority representation should not be evaluated solely through group-specific outcomes or racial gaps. When local policies are attached to places, their effects may extend to residents of different racial groups who share the same neighborhoods. Second, neighborhood stabilization and racial integration need not move together. Place-based improvements can strengthen historically disadvantaged neighborhoods while increasing segregation through endogenous residential sorting. Where integration is also a policy objective, investments in disadvantaged neighborhoods may need to be paired with policies that reduce barriers to mobility and expand access to high-quality neighborhoods.

The findings also speak to ongoing debates over the institutional protection of minority electoral representation.[20] This paper does not study redistricting, and its estimates should not be read as the effects of electoral maps. Even so, the results show that minority representation can have consequences beyond the identity of the officeholder. By shaping neighborhood conditions, residential retention, and urban population composition, access to minority political representation may affect the long-run development of the communities represented.

Several limitations remain. The North Carolina data cover registered voters rather than the full population, and the national data do not permit a direct decomposition of population change into inflows and outflows. The national stock estimates are correspondingly less precise, and the pooled estimates for all residents are further attenuated by declines in racial and ethnic categories the tables do not report separately. The close-election design also identifies effects for competitive elections between Black and white candidates. The estimates may not generalize to elections decided by large margins, to cities without competitive Black candidates, or to institutional settings in which mayors hold substantially different powers. They should likewise be read as the reduced-form effect of electing a Black rather than a white candidate in a close election, not the effect of mayoral race holding every other candidate characteristic fixed. Black and white candidates may differ in unobserved backgrounds, political networks, policy priorities, governing coalitions, or leadership styles, and those differences may themselves be channels through which Black representation affects neighborhood outcomes. Their presence does not invalidate the reduced-form estimates, but it does limit what can be said about the role of race *per se*. Future work could draw on detailed information about candidates, appointments, municipal budgets, permitting decisions, infrastructure investments, and household-level housing outcomes to identify the policies and mayoral characteristics underlying the migration response.

[20] For example, in *Louisiana v. Callais*, Nos. 24-109 and 24-110 (U.S. Apr. 29, 2026), the Supreme Court affirmed the invalidation of Louisiana's congressional map, which contained a second majority-Black district, as an unconstitutional racial gerrymander. The decision was followed by renewed redistricting efforts involving districts with large minority populations in several Southern states.

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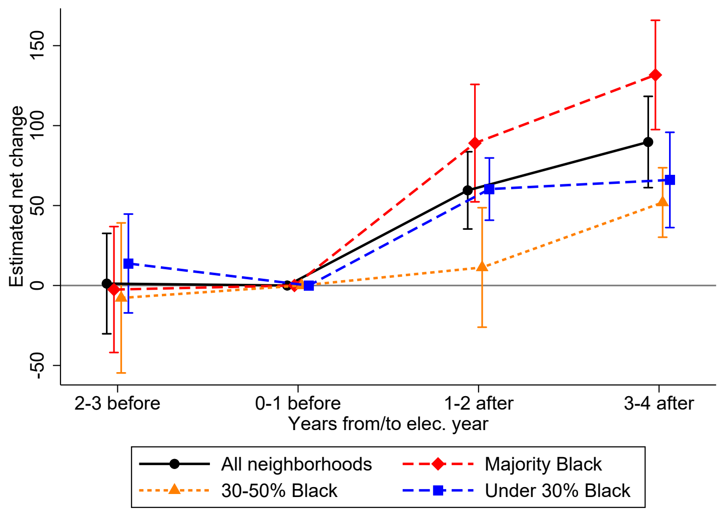
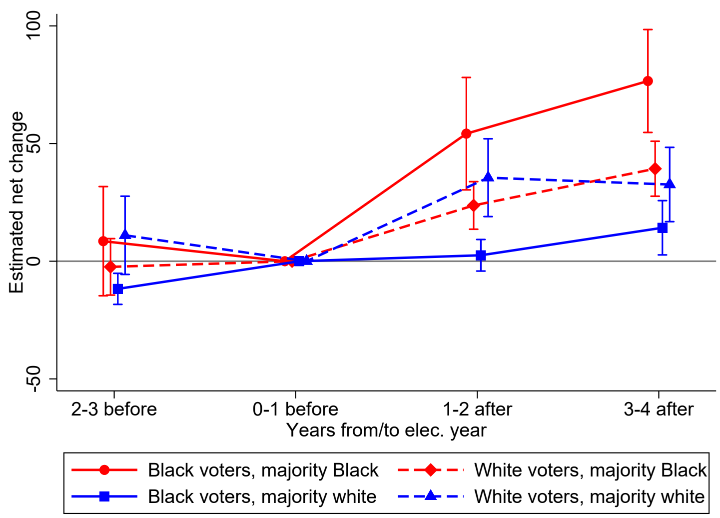
10 Figures

Figure 1: *Net population change (North Carolina)*



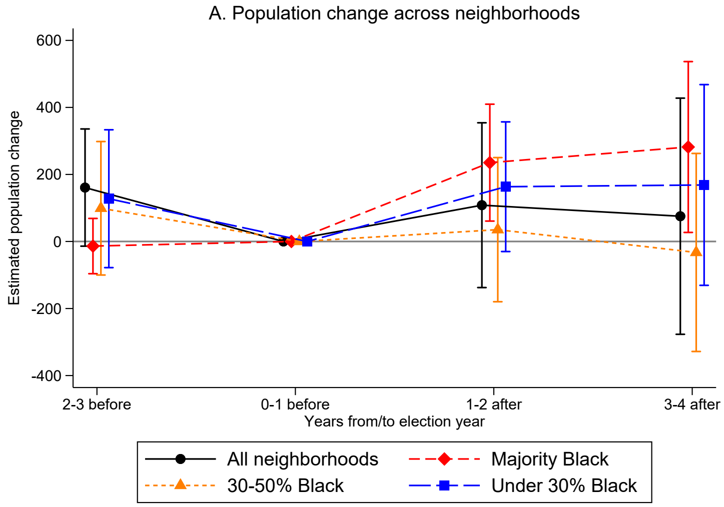
(a) *Net population change across neighborhoods*



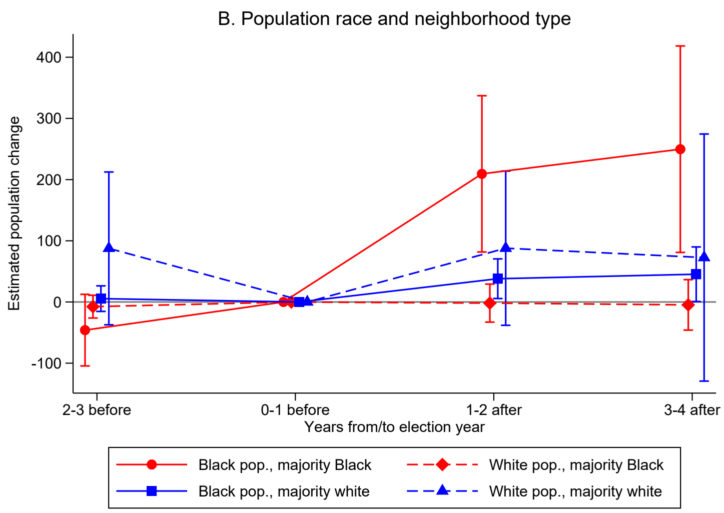
(b) *Net population change of Black and white voters*

Notes: Net population change is the number of voter inflows minus voter outflows in a tract-year. The coefficients are event-time estimates from the stacked difference-in-differences design. The election year is excluded, and the period zero to one year before the election is the omitted category. Panel (a) reports estimates for all tracts and separately for mutually exclusive neighborhood categories: majority-Black tracts (Black share at least 50%), diverse tracts (Black share from 30% to less than 50%), and low-Black-share tracts (Black share below 30%). Panel (b) reports estimates separately for Black and white voters in majority-Black and majority-white tracts; majority-white tracts have a white population share of at least 50% and are distinct from the low-Black-share category in panel (a). The sample is restricted to elections decided by a vote-share margin of less than 10 percentage points, the optimal bandwidth for North Carolina. Regressions are weighted by 2010 tract population. Bars show 95% confidence intervals based on standard errors clustered at the city level.

Figure 2: *Net population change (major U.S. cities)*



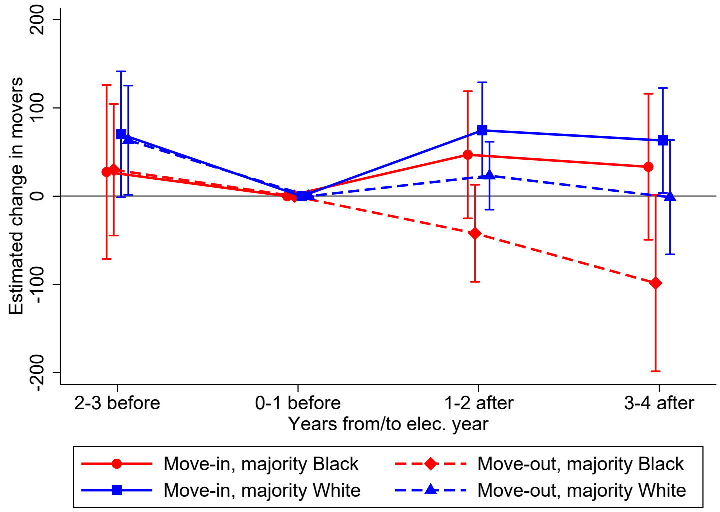
(a) *Net population change across neighborhoods*



(b) *Net population change of Black and white residents*

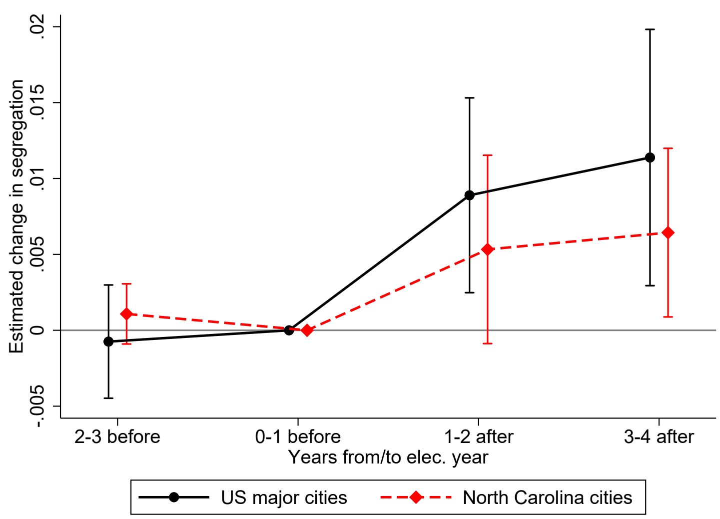
Notes: The outcomes are annual tract-level population counts for the total, Black, and white populations. The coefficients are event-time estimates from the stacked difference-in-differences design and measure changes in population levels relative to the omitted pre-election period; the national data do not separately identify migration inflows and outflows. The election year is excluded, and the period zero to one year before the election is the omitted category. Panel (a) reports estimates for all tracts and separately for mutually exclusive neighborhood categories: majority-Black tracts (Black share at least 50%), diverse tracts (Black share from 30% to less than 50%), and low-Black-share tracts (Black share below 30%). Panel (b) reports estimates separately for Black and white residents in majority-Black and majority-white tracts, where majority-white tracts have a white population share of at least 50%. The sample is restricted to elections decided by a vote-share margin of less than 13 percentage points, the optimal bandwidth for the major-city sample. Regressions are weighted by 2010 tract population. Bars show 95% confidence intervals based on standard errors clustered at the city level.

Figure 3: *Migration inflows and outflows*



Notes: The outcomes are the annual numbers of registered-voter inflows to and outflows from a tract in North Carolina. The coefficients are event-time estimates from the stacked difference-in-differences design. The election year is excluded, and the period zero to one year before the election is the omitted category. Estimates are reported separately for majority-Black tracts (Black share at least 50%) and majority-white tracts (white share at least 50%). The sample is restricted to elections decided by a vote-share margin of less than 10 percentage points, the preferred bandwidth for North Carolina. Regressions are weighted by 2010 tract population. Bars show 95% confidence intervals based on standard errors clustered at the city level.

Figure 4: *Segregation*



Notes: The outcome is the city-level Black–white dissimilarity index, which ranges from zero (complete integration) to one (complete segregation). The coefficients are event-time estimates from the stacked difference-in-differences design. The election year is excluded, and the period zero to one year before the election is the omitted category. The North Carolina sample is restricted to elections decided by less than 10 percentage points, and the major-city sample to elections decided by less than 13 percentage points. North Carolina estimates are weighted by fixed 2010 city population aggregated from 2010 tract populations. Bars show 95% confidence intervals based on standard errors clustered at the city level.

11 Tables

Table 1: *Summary statistics of tract-level demographics*

	NC census data	NC voter registration data	U.S. major cities census data
Total population	2825.9	2012.4	4193.5
Black share	22.9%	24.1%	25.8%
White share	66.2%	69.8%	54.0%
Others	10.9%	6.1%	20.2%
Female/Male	1.1	1.2	1.1

Notes: The table reports tract-level means for the North Carolina census data, the North Carolina voter-registration data, and the census data for the 120 major U.S. cities. Population measures are restricted to individuals ages 20–75 to align the census samples with the voter-registration analysis. Black, white, and other shares are calculated relative to the corresponding tract population.

Table 2: *Summary statistics of mayoral election candidates*

Panel A: North Carolina mayoral candidate characteristics			
	Percent		*Percent*
Black share	15.5%	Democratic	43.86%
White share	82.6%	Republican	9.94%
Other	1.9%	Nonpartisan	40.35%
Female share	24.8%	Unaffiliated	5.85%
Total #	1,177		
Panel B: Mayoral candidate characteristics in major U.S. cities			
	Percent		*Percent*
Black share	21.0%	Democratic	54.5%
White share	72.2%	Republican	24.2%
Other	6.8%	Nonpartisan	20.8%
Female share	19.1%	Unaffiliated	0.6%
Total #	936		

Notes: Panel A summarizes mayoral candidates in North Carolina elections from 2009–2019, and Panel B summarizes candidates in the 120-major-city election sample from 1999–2019. Race, gender, and party affiliation are measured at the candidate level. "Total #" reports the number of candidate observations.

Table 3: *Net population change in North Carolina*

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
	Net population change					
Panel A						
	All tracts			Majority-Black tracts		
	All voters	African American	White	All voters	African American	White
Post × *Blackwin*	68.06***	29.73***	27.78***	103.48***	56.75***	30.76***
	(9.335)	(6.508)	(4.163)	(13.00)	(7.949)	(4.612)
Mean	1,768	636	995	1,682	1,157	379
Close election #	45	45	45	26	26	26
Observations	4,328	4,328	4,328	1,507	1,507	1,507
Panel B						
	30–50% Black tracts			Black share below 30%		
	All voters	African American	White	All voters	African American	White
Post × *Blackwin*	30.07***	15.67***	12.20***	53.92***	9.903*	32.27***
	(5.273)	(3.075)	(3.596)	(6.407)	(5.518)	(6.379)
Mean	1,710	671	898	1,907	237	1,548
Close election #	30	30	30	29	29	29
Observations	738	738	738	1,945	1,945	1,945
FE: Year	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
FE: Election	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
FE: Tract	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

Notes: The dependent variable is tract-level net population change, defined as the number of voter inflows minus voter outflows. *Post* × *Blackwin* is the coefficient β_1 in Equation (1). Majority-Black tracts have a Black population share of at least 50%; diverse tracts have a Black share from 30% to less than 50%; and low-Black-share tracts have a Black share below 30%. These categories are mutually exclusive and are based on 2010 Census composition. The "Mean" row reports the average number of registered voters per tract for the corresponding racial group. The sample is restricted to elections decided by a vote-share margin of less than 10 percentage points, the optimal bandwidth for North Carolina. All specifications include year, election, and tract fixed effects. Regressions are weighted by 2010 tract population. Standard errors are clustered at the city level. Significance levels are denoted by $^{*}p < 0.10$, $^{**}p < 0.05$, and $^{***}p < 0.01$.

Table 4: *Move-in and move-out outcomes*

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
		Move-in			Move-out	
	All voters	African American	White	All voters	African American	White
Panel A: All tracts						
Post × *Blackwin*	26.41**	6.648	12.62**	-41.66***	-23.08***	-15.16***
	(11.06)	(4.742)	(5.677)	(14.63)	(7.902)	(4.348)
Mean	1,768	636	995	1,768	636	995
Close election #	45	45	45	45	45	45
Observations	4,328	4,328	4,328	4,328	4,328	4,328
Panel B: Majority-Black tracts						
Post × *Blackwin*	22.38	12.67	4.010	-81.10***	-44.08***	-26.76***
	(13.51)	(9.390)	(3.718)	(18.60)	(11.22)	(5.540)
Mean	1,682	1,157	379	1,682	1,157	379
Close election #	26	26	26	26	26	26
Observations	1,507	1,507	1,507	1,507	1,507	1,507
Panel C: 30–50% Black tracts						
Post × *Blackwin*	21.26*	9.192	7.802	-8.812	-6.476	-4.394
	(10.94)	(7.088)	(4.672)	(11.14)	(6.168)	(5.203)
Mean	1,710	671	898	1,710	671	898
Close election #	30	30	30	30	30	30
Observations	738	738	738	738	738	738
Panel D: Black share below 30%						
Post × *Blackwin*	33.21**	0.699	20.52**	-20.71*	-9.204*	-11.75**
	(13.26)	(3.182)	(8.167)	(12.00)	(4.471)	(5.345)
Mean	1,907	237	1,548	1,907	237	1,548
Close election #	29	29	29	29	29	29
Observations	1,945	1,945	1,945	1,945	1,945	1,945
FE: Year	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
FE: Election	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
FE: Tract	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

Notes: "Move-in" is the annual number of registered-voter inflows to a tract, and "Move-out" is the annual number of registered-voter outflows from a tract. *Post* × *Blackwin* is the coefficient β_1 in Equation (1). Majority-Black tracts have a Black population share of at least 50%; diverse tracts have a Black share from 30% to less than 50%; and low-Black-share tracts have a Black share below 30%. The "Mean" row reports the average number of registered voters per tract for the corresponding racial group. The sample is restricted to elections decided by a vote-share margin of less than 10 percentage points, the optimal bandwidth for North Carolina. All specifications include year, election, and tract fixed effects. Regressions are weighted by 2010 tract population. Standard errors are clustered at the city level. Significance levels are denoted by $^{*}p < 0.10$, $^{**}p < 0.05$, and $^{***}p < 0.01$.

Table 5: *Tract population levels in major U.S. cities*

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
	Tract population level					
Panel A	All tracts			Majority-Black tracts		
	All population	African American	White	All population	African American	White
Post*Blackwin	6.33	76.91*	13.82	262.40**	251.72***	0.09
	(181.67)	(38.62)	(55.89)	(122.30)	(79.38)	(18.14)
Mean	4651	1099	2204	3584	2594	531
Close election #	52	52	52	51	51	51
Observations	65176	65077	65103	15748	15690	15715
Panel B	30-50% Black tracts			Black share below 30%		
	All population	African American	White	All population	African American	White
Post*Blackwin	-49.38	80.68	59.26*	98.39	30.36*	73.25
	(156.80)	(67.80)	(30.54)	(157.95)	(17.24)	(99.05)
Mean	4702	1693	1503	4662	427	3565
Close election #	51	51	51	52	52	52
Observations	4983	4983	4970	28310	28280	28306
FE: Year	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
FE: Election	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
FE: Tract	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

Notes: The dependent variables are annual tract-level population counts for the total, Black, and white populations ages 20–75. $Post \times Blackwin$ is the coefficient β_1 in Equation (1). Majority-Black tracts have a Black share of at least 50%; diverse tracts have a Black share from 30% to less than 50%; and low-Black-share tracts have a Black share below 30%. These categories are mutually exclusive. The "Mean" row reports the corresponding average population per tract. The sample is restricted to elections decided by a vote-share margin of less than 13 percentage points, the optimal bandwidth for the major-city sample. Regressions are weighted by 2010 tract population. Standard errors are clustered at the city level. Significance levels are denoted by $^{*}p < 0.10$, $^{**}p < 0.05$, and $^{***}p < 0.01$.

Table 6: *Black share across neighborhoods*

	(1)	(3)	(2)	(4)
Panel A: North Carolina	Black share			
	All	50% more	30-50%	30% less
PostXBlackwin	0.00562*	0.01262***	0.00609	0.00283
	(0.00310)	(0.00359)	(0.00590)	(0.00485)
Mean	0.379	0.682	0.407	0.136
Close election #	45	26	30	29
Observations	4328	1507	738	1945
Panel B: US major cities	All	50% more	30-50%	30% less
PostXBlackwin	0.00733***	0.01593***	0.02051**	0.00273
	(0.00257)	(0.00429)	(0.00815)	(0.00180)
Mean	0.272	0.740	0.361	0.092
Close election #	52	51	51	52
Observations	65077	15690	4983	28280
FE: Year	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
FE: Election	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
FE: Tract	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

Notes: The dependent variable is the Black share of the tract population. $Post \times Blackwin$ is the coefficient β_1 in Equation (1). Majority-Black tracts have a Black share of at least 50%; diverse tracts have a Black share from 30% to less than 50%; and low-Black-share tracts have a Black share below 30%. Panel A uses the North Carolina voter-registration sample and elections decided by less than 10 percentage points. Panel B uses the major-city census sample and elections decided by less than 13 percentage points. The "Mean" row reports the average pre-treatment Black share in the corresponding sample. Regressions are weighted by 2010 tract population. Standard errors are clustered at the city level. Significance levels are denoted by $^{*}p < 0.10$, $^{**}p < 0.05$, and $^{***}p < 0.01$.

Table 7: *Neighborhood heterogeneity in racial sorting*

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
		Net population change		Black share
Panel A: North Carolina				
		Baseline: Black share below 30%		
	All voters	African American	White	Black share
Post × *Blackwin*	49.91***	-1.19	43.68***	0.0010
	(10.939)	(3.189)	(8.507)	(0.0042)
Post × *Blackwin* × *Diverse*	22.30	42.60***	-21.15*	0.0044
	(16.946)	(8.661)	(10.947)	(0.0062)
Post × *Blackwin* × *Majority Black*	44.65**	69.69***	-37.63***	0.0177*
	(17.803)	(11.111)	(9.704)	(0.0092)
Mean	1,850	247	1,476	0.151
Close election #	45	45	45	45
Observations	4,328	4,328	4,328	4,328
Panel B: Major U.S. cities				
		Baseline: Black share below 30%		
	All population	Black population	White population	Black share
Post × *Blackwin*	-46.04	35.80	6.98	0.0027
	(182.809)	(23.946)	(76.053)	(0.0029)
Post × *Blackwin* × *Diverse*	43.73	-24.05	119.99	0.0114
	(92.655)	(73.707)	(106.418)	(0.0074)
Post × *Blackwin* × *Majority Black*	423.80**	238.92***	41.99	0.0273***
	(190.530)	(60.302)	(118.459)	(0.0038)
Mean	5,024	504	2,875	0.097
Close election #	52	52	52	52
Observations	65,176	65,077	65,103	65,077
FE: Year	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
FE: Election	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
FE: Tract	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

Notes: Columns (1)–(3) report tract-level net population change for all, Black, and White voters or residents; column (4) reports the tract Black population share. The omitted neighborhood category consists of tracts with a Black population share below 30%. Diverse tracts have a Black share from 30% to less than 50%, and Majority-Black tracts have a Black share of at least 50%. *Post* × *Blackwin* reports the estimated effect for the omitted neighborhood category, while the triple-interaction coefficients report differences relative to that category. The "Mean" row reports the average tract count for the corresponding population group and the average Black share within the omitted category. The North Carolina sample is restricted to elections decided within 10 percentage points; the major-city sample is restricted to elections decided within 13 percentage points. Regressions are weighted by 2010 tract population. Standard errors are clustered at the city level. Significance levels are denoted by $^{*}p < 0.10$, $^{**}p < 0.05$, and $^{***}p < 0.01$.

Table 8: *Housing price index*

	(1)	(2)
	log(HPI)	log(HPI)
PostXBlackwin	0.0407***	0.0223**
	(0.0107)	(0.00978)
PostXBlackwinXDiverse		0.00547
		(0.00634)
PostXBlackwinXMajorBlack		0.0361**
		(0.0142)
Close election #	39	39
Observations	5654	5654
FE: Tract	Yes	Yes
FE: Year	Yes	Yes
FE: Election	Yes	Yes

Notes: The dependent variable is the logarithm of the tract-level FHFA House Price Index after accounting for a city-specific time trend. I use the log of the FHFA house price index so that coefficients are interpretable as percentage changes and comparable across neighborhoods with different baseline price levels. Observations in the bottom and top 1% of the HPI distribution are excluded. The omitted category is tracts with a Black share below 30%. *Post*×*Blackwin*×*Diverse* and *Post*×*Blackwin*×*MajorBlack* are differential effects for diverse tracts (Black share from 30% to less than 50%) and majority-Black tracts (Black share at least 50%), respectively. The sample is restricted to elections decided by a vote-share margin of less than 10 percentage points. Standard errors are clustered at the city level. Significance levels are denoted by $^{*}p < 0.10$, $^{**}p < 0.05$, and $^{***}p < 0.01$.

Table 9: *Toxics Release Inventory outcomes*

	(1) Extensive TRI	(2) Intensive TRI	(3) Aggregated TRI
PostXBlackwin	-0.00172	0.207***	0.194**
	(0.00575)	(0.0688)	(0.0833)
PostXBlackwinXMajorBlack	-0.00433	-0.164**	-0.183*
	(0.00949)	(0.0783)	(0.0998)
Mean	0.14	2.39	0.33
Close elections #	44	30	44
Method	OLS	Poisson	Poisson
Observations	13023	1781	13023
FE: Block group	Yes	Yes	Yes
FE: Year	Yes	Yes	Yes
FE: Election	Yes	Yes	Yes

Notes: Column 1 uses an indicator equal to one if the block group contains at least one Toxics Release Inventory (TRI) facility and is estimated by OLS. Columns 2 and 3 use the number of TRI facilities and are estimated by Poisson pseudo-maximum likelihood with the fixed effects shown in the table; column 2 uses block groups with positive TRI counts, while column 3 uses all block groups. $Post \times Blackwin$ is the effect for the omitted category, block groups with a Black share below 30%. $Post \times Blackwin \times MajorBlack$ is the differential effect for majority-Black block groups, defined as having a Black share of at least 50%. The sample is restricted to elections decided by a vote-share margin of less than 10 percentage points. All specifications include block-group, year, and election fixed effects. Standard errors are clustered at the city level. Significance levels are denoted by $^{*}p < 0.10$, $^{**}p < 0.05$, and $^{***}p < 0.01$.

Table 10: *Local media coverage*

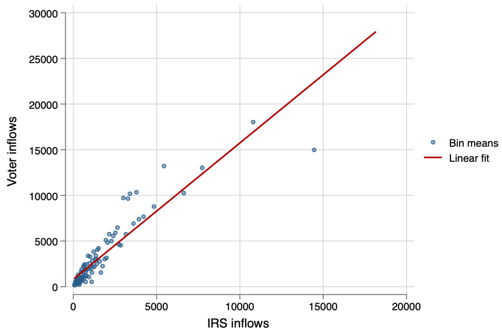
	(1) Extensive Cov	(2) Intensive Cov	(3) Aggregated Cov	(4) Share of Cov
Post x Blackwin	-0.0702**	-0.116	-0.137*	0.000130
	(0.0290)	(0.0800)	(0.0820)	(0.000377)
Post x Blackwin x Blackneigh	0.0810*	0.113**	0.155***	0.00113*
	(0.0392)	(0.0510)	(0.0486)	(0.000621)
Mean	0.8	652.8	557.3	0.01
# of Local news	Yes	Yes	Yes	
Close elections #	34	33	34	34
Observations	28808	23234	27212	27893
FE: Neighborhood	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
FE: Year	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
FE: Election	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

Notes: The unit of observation is a neighborhood-year in the major-city media sample. The comparison group consists of neighborhoods with a Black population share below 30%, and *Blackneigh* identifies neighborhoods with a Black share of at least 30%. This broader definition is used because fewer than 20 majority-Black neighborhoods are observed in cities with close elections. Column 1 measures whether the neighborhood receives any local newspaper coverage. Columns 2 and 3 measure the frequency with which the neighborhood's name appears in local newspaper coverage under the intensive and aggregate specifications shown in the table. Column 4 measures the neighborhood's share of total neighborhood coverage in the city. Columns 1–3 are estimated by Poisson pseudo-maximum likelihood, and column 4 by OLS. The sample is restricted to elections decided by a vote-share margin of less than 13 percentage points, the optimal bandwidth for the major-city sample. Standard errors are clustered at the city level. Significance levels are denoted by $^{*}p < 0.10$, $^{**}p < 0.05$, and $^{***}p < 0.01$.

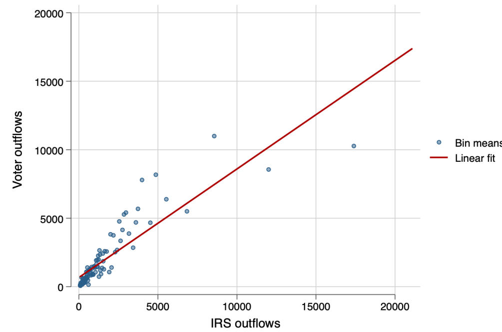
A Online Appendix

A.1 Figures

Figure A.1: *Cross-county migration data comparison—voter data vs. IRS data*



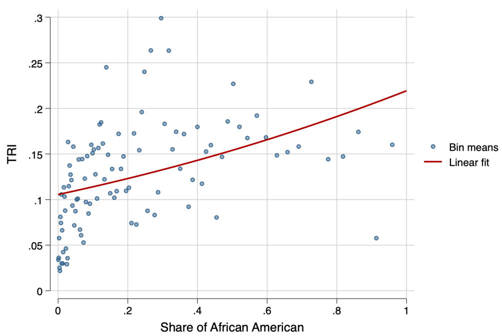
(a) *County-level inflows*



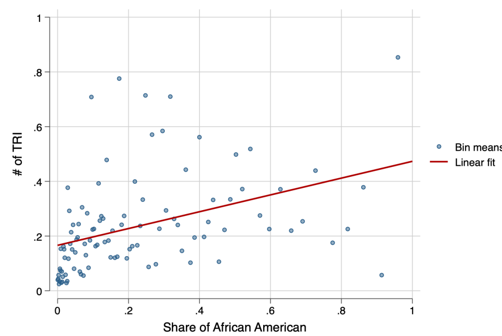
(b) *County-level outflows*

Notes: Panel (a) compares annual county-level inflows constructed from the North Carolina voter-registration records with county-level inflows reported by the Internal Revenue Service; panel (b) makes the analogous comparison for outflows. The voter measures aggregate changes in registered residential addresses, while the IRS measures are based on address changes reported on tax returns. Points are binned means, and the solid line is the fitted linear relationship. This figure is descriptive and is not restricted to the close-election sample.

Figure A.2: *Distribution of Toxics Release Inventory facilities.*



(a) *TRI dummy distribution*



(b) *TRI numbers distribution*

Notes: Panel (a) plots the relationship between a block group's Black population share and an indicator equal to one if the block group contains at least one Toxics Release Inventory (TRI) facility. Panel (b) uses the number of TRI facilities in the block group. Points are binned means, and the solid line is the fitted linear relationship.

A.2 Tables

Table A.1: *Summary statistics of migration inflows and outflows in North Carolina*

	Obs	Mean	Std. Dev.	Min	Max	Share of total inflows/outflows
Blockgroup inflows	89,375	58.814	79.16	0	2355	1.000
City inflows	89,375	44.499	64.17	0	2329	0.757
County inflows	89,375	37.902	56.18	0	2323	0.644
Blockgroup outflows	81,688	45.079	53.10	0	3112	1.000
City outflows	81,688	30.940	38.90	0	1990	0.686
County outflows	81,688	24.378	32.20	0	1869	0.541

Notes: The unit of observation is a block group-year in the North Carolina voter-registration data. Block-group inflows and outflows count all registered-voter moves into and out of the block group. City inflows count movers entering the block group from outside the city, and city outflows count movers leaving the block group for a location outside the city. County inflows and outflows are defined analogously using county boundaries. The final column reports each cross-boundary measure as a share of total block-group inflows or outflows.

Table A.2: *Pre-election city-level demographics mean comparison*

Panel A: North Carolina		
	Black mayor cities	*White mayor cities*
Total population	43,734.5	27,385.3
Black population	15,173.9	8,922.4
Black share	36.9%	32.9%
# of cities	45	78
Panel B: Major U.S. cities		
	Black mayor cities	*White mayor cities*
Total population	653,366.2	680,528.8
Black population	170,503.3	171,056.7
Black share	26.8%	25.1%
# of cities	45	47

Notes: The table reports mean pre-election city-level demographics in the unrestricted sample, separately for cities that elect a Black mayor and cities that elect a white mayor. Population refers to residents ages 20–75, and Black share is the Black population divided by total population. These descriptive comparisons are not restricted to close elections.

Table A.3: *Summary Statistics of Mayoral election candidates for final sample*

Panel A: North Carolina mayor candidates characteristics (final sample)			
	Percent		Percent
Black share	50.0%	Democratic	44.41%
White share	50.0%	Republican	11.47%
Female share	26.9%	Non Partisan	38.82%
Total #	432	Unaffiliated	5.29%
Panel B: U.S. major cities mayor candidates characteristics (final sample)			
	Percent		Percent
Black share	50.0%	Democratic	65.49%
White share	50.0%	Republican	17.3%
Female share	19.5%	Non Partisan	1.6%
Total #	452.0	Unaffiliated	0.9%

Notes: The table summarizes candidates in the final election samples used in the analysis, which are restricted to contests between a Black and a white candidate. Panel A reports North Carolina candidates, and Panel B reports candidates in the major-city sample. Race, gender, and party affiliation are measured at the candidate level. Race shares equal 50% by construction because each included contest contributes one Black and one white candidate.

Table A.4: *Summary Statistics of Housing Price Index*

Neighborhoods (tracts)	Obs	Mean	Std. dev.	Min	Max
All	42,137	168.0813	64.10188	59.4	778.95
Black share $\leq$ 30%	32,163	174.6233	66.86476	71.87	778.95
Black share $<$50%, $>$30%	5,555	151.8465	44.32873	60.77	513.07
Black share $\geq$ 50%	4,026	137.6455	49.07256	59.4	478.88

Notes: The table reports summary statistics for the tract-level FHFA House Price Index after excluding observations in the bottom and top 1% of the HPI distribution.

Table A.5: *Summary Statistics of Public School Enrollment*

North Carolina K12 Public school enrollment	
	Percent
Black share	28.2%
White share	51.1%
Others	20.6%
Female	52.8%

Notes: The table reports the racial and gender composition of enrollment in the North Carolina K–12 public-school sample from 2004–2019.

Table A.6: *Summary Statistics of Local News and Neighborhood Demographics*

	Obs	Mean	Std. Dev.	Min	Max
Population	52,488	6873.293	15746.11	0.0002741	216437.3
Black share	52,488	0.2776021	0.2587979	0	0.9856255
Media coverage	52,488	656.8309	1788.87	0	37730

Notes: The unit of observation is a neighborhood-year in the major-city media sample. Population and Black share are constructed by overlaying neighborhood boundaries with census geography. Media coverage is the number of local newspaper pages that mention both the neighborhood name and its city. The sample covers neighborhoods for which both geographic boundaries and digitized local newspaper archives are available.

Table A.7: *Cross-city move-in move-out outcomes*

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
		Move-in			Move out	
	All voters	African American	White	All voters	African American	White
			Panel A: All tracts			
Post*Blackwin	26.374***	8.065***	10.900**	-29.070***	-15.636***	-13.675***
	(8.338)	(2.696)	(5.018)	(8.510)	(4.828)	(3.868)
Mean	1768	636	995	1768	636	995
Close election #	45	45	45	45	45	45
Observations	4328	4328	4328	4328	4328	4328
			Panel B: Majority-Black tracts			
Post*Blackwin	27.090**	14.597**	3.871	-49.328***	-24.277***	-26.811***
	(10.548)	(5.419)	(3.345)	(10.808)	(5.792)	(5.348)
Mean	1682	1157	379	1682	1157	379
Close election #	26	26	26	26	26	26
Observations	1507	1507	1507	1507	1507	1507
			Panel C: 30%-50% black tracts			
Post*Blackwin	21.744**	7.976*	8.231*	-6.140	-5.779	-3.119
	(8.780)	(4.412)	(3.989)	(8.411)	(4.028)	(4.467)
Mean	1710	671	898	1710	671	898
Close election #	30	30	30	30	30	30
Observations	738	738	738	738	738	738
			Panel D: Black share below 30%			
Post*Blackwin	27.428***	3.277	15.913**	-20.593***	-8.709**	-9.163**
	(8.902)	(2.592)	(6.379)	(7.056)	(3.974)	(3.501)
Mean	1907	237	1548	1907	237	1548
Close election #	29	29	29	29	29	29
Observations	1945	1945	1945	1945	1945	1945
FE: Year	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
FE: Election	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

Notes: "Move-in" is the annual number of registered voters entering a tract from outside the city, and "Move-out" is the annual number leaving the tract for a location outside the city. Outcomes are reported for all voters and separately for Black and white voters. $Post \times Blackwin$ is the coefficient β_1 in Equation (1). Majority-Black tracts have a Black share of at least 50%; diverse tracts have a Black share from 30% to less than 50%; and low-Black-share tracts have a Black share below 30%. The "Mean" row reports the average number of registered voters per tract for the corresponding racial group. The sample is restricted to elections decided by a vote-share margin of less than 10 percentage points. Standard errors are clustered at the city level. Significance levels are denoted by $^{*}p < 0.10$, $^{**}p < 0.05$, and $^{***}p < 0.01$.

Table A.8: *Public school enrollment*

	(1) All	(2) African American	(3) White
Post*Blackwin	24.88**	1.043	6.023
	(10.29)	(5.044)	(5.883)
Post*BlackwinXDiverse	35.01***	6.492	2.368
	(12.62)	(9.437)	(5.648)
Post*BlackwinXMajorBlack	34.25*	31.95**	-4.052
	(19.46)	(11.83)	(5.281)
Mean	657.8	281.4	211.7
Close elections #	44	44	44
Observations	6166	6166	6166
FE: School	Yes	Yes	Yes
FE: Year	Yes	Yes	Yes
FE: Election	Yes	Yes	Yes

Notes: The dependent variables are total, Black, and white enrollment at the school-year level. Schools are assigned to the tract in which they are located. The omitted category consists of schools in tracts with a Black share below 30%. *Post* × *Blackwin* × *Diverse* and *Post* × *Blackwin* × *MajorBlack* report differential effects for schools in diverse tracts (Black share from 30% to less than 50%) and majority-Black tracts (Black share at least 50%), respectively. The "Mean" row reports average enrollment in the corresponding student group. The sample is restricted to elections decided by a vote-share margin of less than 10 percentage points. Standard errors are clustered at the city level. Significance levels are denoted by $^{*}p < 0.10$, $^{**}p < 0.05$, and $^{***}p < 0.01$.

Table A.9: *Crimes reported and arrests*

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
	Total arrests per 100 capita				Crime reported per 100 capita
	All	African American	white	Black share	All
PostXBlackwin	-0.0433	-0.0588	-0.0336	0.00253	-0.107
	(0.0842)	(0.0486)	(0.0359)	(0.0178)	(0.147)
Mean	3	2	1	0.6	4.7
Observations	202	202	202	202	278
Close election #	35	35	35	35	43
FE: Year	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
FE: Election	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

Notes: The unit of observation is a city-year. Columns 1–3 report total, Black, and white arrests per 100 residents; column 4 reports the Black share of arrests; and column 5 reports crimes known to law enforcement per 100 residents. The sample is restricted to elections decided by a vote-share margin of less than 10 percentage points. Standard errors are clustered at the city level. Significance levels are denoted by $^{*}p < 0.10$, $^{**}p < 0.05$, and $^{***}p < 0.01$.

Table A.10: *Balance test for pre-election city-level demographics*

Panel A: North Carolina	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
	Population	Black pop	log(pop)	log(Black pop)	Black share
Blackwin	8005.4	4064.9	-0.3660	-0.0956	0.0587
	(34190.3)	(11225.2)	(0.581)	(0.628)	(0.0555)
Observations	131	131	131	131	131
Panel B: US major cities					
Blackwin	47579.7	16465.0	0.0149	0.0637	0.0468
	(155467.0)	(52775.7)	(0.237)	(0.339)	(0.0406)
Observations	187	187	187	187	187
Close election	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
FE: Year	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

Notes: The table tests whether pre-election city-level demographic characteristics differ between cities in which a Black candidate narrowly wins and cities in which a Black candidate narrowly loses. The outcomes are total population, Black population, their logarithms, and the Black population share. Panel A uses North Carolina elections decided by less than 10 percentage points; panel B uses major-city elections decided by less than 13 percentage points. Standard errors are clustered at the city level. Significance levels are denoted by $^{*}p < 0.10$, $^{**}p < 0.05$, and $^{***}p < 0.01$.

Table A.11: *Pre-election net population change in North Carolina*

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
	Pre-election net population change					
Panel A	All tracts			Majority-Black tracts		
	All voters	African American	White	All voters	African American	White
Blackwin	-2.30	1.99	-2.08	-6.31	-2.11	-2.09
	(8.705)	(3.506)	(4.395)	(9.291)	(5.822)	(2.472)
Mean	-4.19	-3.94	-4.07	-9.21	-8.57	-2.67
Close election #	35	35	35	20	20	20
Observations	1937	1937	1937	629	629	629
Panel B	30-50% Black tracts			30% less Black tracts		
	All voters	African American	White	All voters	African American	White
Blackwin	21.42	11.08*	9.73	-10.58	2.41***	-11.35**
	(12.444)	(5.345)	(6.303)	(6.207)	(0.831)	(4.596)
Mean	-10.01	-3.12	-10.60	1.58	-1.35	-2.60
Close election #	22	22	22	22	22	22
Observations	339	339	339	910	910	910
FE: Year	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
FE: Tract	No	No	No	No	No	No

Notes: The dependent variable is pre-election tract-level net population change, defined as the number of voter inflows minus voter outflows, reported for all voters and separately for Black and white voters. Majority-Black tracts have a Black share of at least 50%; diverse tracts have a Black share from 30% to less than 50%; and low-Black-share tracts have a Black share below 30%. The "Mean" row reports average pre-election net population change per tract. The sample is restricted to elections decided by a vote-share margin of less than 10 percentage points, the optimal bandwidth for North Carolina. Standard errors are clustered at the city level. Significance levels are denoted by $^{*}p < 0.10$, $^{**}p < 0.05$, and $^{***}p < 0.01$.

Table A.12: *Pre-election tract population levels in major U.S. cities*

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
	Pre-election tract population level					
Panel A	All tracts			Majority-Black tracts		
	All voters	African American	White	All voters	African American	White
Blackwin	201.56*	-35.77	-6.60	16.30	-119.66***	-22.94*
	(115.900)	(28.814)	(28.194)	(73.815)	(42.802)	(12.515)
Mean	4820.16	1061.90	2213.71	3786.95	2704.03	531.77
Close election #	37	37	37	36	36	36
Observations	32453	32406	32427	6832	6804	6824
Panel B	30-50% Black tracts			30% less Black tracts		
	All voters	African American	White	All voters	African American	White
Blackwin	136.18	-24.36	-105.09*	121.52	-15.61	38.67
	(87.798)	(34.001)	(56.991)	(194.282)	(22.232)	(97.254)
Mean	4872.90	1734.43	1391.13	4794.46	426.79	3607.30
Close election #	36	36	36	37	37	37
Observations	2377	2377	2372	13497	13483	13493
FE: Year	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
FE: Tract	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

Notes: The dependent variables are pre-election tract-level population counts for the total, Black, and white populations. Majority-Black tracts have a Black share of at least 50%; diverse tracts have a Black share from 30% to less than 50%; and low-Black-share tracts have a Black share below 30%. The "Mean" row reports the corresponding average pre-election population per tract. The sample is restricted to elections decided by a vote-share margin of less than 13 percentage points, the optimal bandwidth for the major-city sample. Standard errors are clustered at the city level. Significance levels are denoted by $^{*}p < 0.10$, $^{**}p < 0.05$, and $^{***}p < 0.01$.

Table A.13: *Party affiliation and net population change*

	(1)	(2)	(3)
	Net population change		
Panel A	All tracts		
	All voters	African American	White
Post*Demwin	20.914*	7.106***	9.644
	(10.397)	(1.259)	(8.327)
Mean	1721	621	958
Close election #	31	31	31
Observations	3652	3652	3652
Panel B	Black share >30% tracts		
	All voters	African American	White
Post*Demwin	1.820	4.808	-1.746
	(4.006)	(3.285)	(1.166)
Mean	1624	982	490
Close election #	21	21	21
Observations	1911	1911	1911
Panel C	Black share <30% tracts		
	All voters	African American	White
Post*Demwin	28.159***	6.806***	19.418**
	(7.391)	(1.878)	(8.092)
Mean	1826	225	1473
Close election #	19	19	19
Observations	1741	1741	1741
FE: Year	Yes	Yes	Yes
FE: Election	Yes	Yes	Yes
FE: Tract	Yes	Yes	Yes

Notes: The sample is restricted to close elections between Democratic and non-Democratic candidates. The dependent variable is tract-level net population change, defined as voter inflows minus voter outflows, reported for all voters and separately for Black and white voters. *Post* × *Demwin* measures the effect of a narrow Democratic victory. Panel B includes tracts with a Black share of at least 30%, and panel C includes tracts with a Black share below 30%. The "Mean" row reports the average number of registered voters per tract for the corresponding racial group. The sample is restricted to elections decided by a vote-share margin of less than 13 percentage points, the optimal bandwidth for this party-election exercise. Standard errors are clustered at the city level. Significance levels are denoted by $^{*}p < 0.10$, $^{**}p < 0.05$, and $^{***}p < 0.01$.

Table A.14: *Results with party controls*

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
	Net population change					
Panel A	All tracts			Majority-Black tracts		
	All voters	African American	White	All voters	African American	White
Post*Blackwin	71.64***	28.09***	28.53***	94.34***	60.42**	18.41***
	(18.870)	(8.730)	(8.171)	(30.313)	(21.587)	(3.712)
Post*Demwin	-5.05	2.32	-1.07	12.24	-4.92	16.54***
	(19.628)	(9.170)	(10.422)	(31.070)	(21.974)	(3.868)
Mean	1768	636	995	1682	1157	379
Close election #	45	45	45	26	26	26
Observations	4328	4328	4328	1507	1507	1507
Panel B	30-50% Black tracts			30% less Black tracts		
	All voters	African American	White	All voters	African American	White
Post*Blackwin	46.16***	24.18***	16.42	60.92***	7.65	32.66***
	(13.648)	(4.631)	(9.661)	(13.095)	(6.028)	(8.726)
Post*Demwin	-23.04	-12.19**	-6.05	-10.65	3.43	-0.60
	(15.089)	(4.780)	(9.901)	(14.979)	(6.482)	(13.528)
Mean	1710	671	898	1907	237	1548
Close election #	30	30	30	29	29	29
Observations	738	738	738	1945	1945	1945
FE: Year	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
FE: Election	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
FE: Tract	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

Notes: The dependent variable is tract-level net population change, defined as voter inflows minus voter outflows. Majority-Black tracts have a Black share of at least 50%; diverse tracts have a Black share from 30% to less than 50%; and low-Black-share tracts have a Black share below 30%. The "Mean" row reports the average number of registered voters per tract for the corresponding racial group. The sample is restricted to elections decided by a vote-share margin of less than 10 percentage points. Standard errors are clustered at the city level. Significance levels are denoted by $^{*}p < 0.10$, $^{**}p < 0.05$, and $^{***}p < 0.01$.

Table A.15: *Results with the stricter migration standard*

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
	Net population change					
Panel A	All tracts			Majority-Black tracts		
	All voters	African American	White	All voters	African American	White
PostXBlackwin	49.26***	17.51***	20.75***	67.46***	36.10***	16.14***
	(7.244)	(4.230)	(4.373)	(10.666)	(7.293)	(2.873)
Mean	1769	637	996	1682	1157	379
Close election #	45	45	45	26	26	26
Observations	4328	4328	4328	1507	1507	1507
Panel B	30-50% Black tracts			Black share below 30%		
	All voters	African American	White	All voters	African American	White
PostXBlackwin	29.14***	11.50***	11.65***	41.63***	3.93	26.63***
	(6.036)	(3.927)	(3.478)	(7.490)	(3.758)	(6.302)
Mean	1712	672	899	1908	237	1550
Close election #	30	30	30	29	29	29
Observations	738	738	738	1945	1945	1945
FE: Year	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
FE: Election	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
FE: Tract	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

Notes: The dependent variable is tract-level net population change under the stricter migration standard, which excludes each voter's first and final registration records. Net population change is constructed as winsorized inflows minus winsorized outflows. The sample is restricted to elections decided within 10 percentage points. All specifications include year, election, and tract fixed effects, with standard errors clustered at the city level. Significance levels are denoted by $^{*}p < 0.10$, $^{**}p < 0.05$, and $^{***}p < 0.01$.

Table A.16: *Net population change without reelected Black mayors*

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
	Net population change					
Panel A	All tracts			Majority-Black tracts		
	All voters	African American	White	All voters	African American	White
PostXBlackwin	55.23***	23.19***	22.95***	78.14***	43.32**	18.78***
	(11.008)	(4.974)	(7.570)	(19.811)	(17.317)	(4.189)
Mean	1787	614	1045	1744	1198	404
Close election #	43	43	43	24	24	24
Observations	2504	2504	2504	727	727	727
Panel B	30-50% Black tracts			Black share below 30%		
	All voters	African American	White	All voters	African American	White
PostXBlackwin	31.45***	16.53***	12.74*	47.65***	6.78	29.45**
	(8.284)	(5.162)	(6.968)	(10.307)	(4.099)	(10.817)
Mean	1739	682	929	1875	256	1503
Close election #	28	28	28	27	27	27
Observations	498	498	498	1225	1225	1225
FE: Year	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
FE: Election	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
FE: Tract	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

Notes: The dependent variable is tract-level net population change, defined as voter inflows minus voter outflows. The sample excludes elections in which an incumbent Black mayor is re-elected. $Post \times Blackwin$ is the coefficient β_1 in Equation (1). Majority-Black tracts have a Black share of at least 50%; diverse tracts have a Black share from 30% to less than 50%; and low-Black-share tracts have a Black share below 30%. The "Mean" row reports the average number of registered voters per tract for the corresponding racial group. The sample is restricted to elections decided by a vote-share margin of less than 10 percentage points. Standard errors are clustered at the city level. Significance levels are denoted by $^{*}p < 0.10$, $^{**}p < 0.05$, and $^{***}p < 0.01$.

Table A.17: *Net population change in North Carolina with multiple bandwidths*

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
	Net population change				
Panel A	All voters				
	All tracts				
Bandwidth	0.06	0.08	0.10	0.12	0.14
PostXBlackwin	40.22***	69.52***	68.06***	56.95***	56.84***
	(8.943)	(8.423)	(9.335)	(13.485)	(13.528)
Mean	1799	1770	1768	1762	1761
Close election #	29	39	45	55	56
Observations	2321	4190	4328	4718	4723
Panel B	African American				
	All tracts				
Bandwidth	0.06	0.08	0.10	0.12	0.14
PostXBlackwin	18.71***	30.39***	29.73***	24.72***	24.71***
	(4.154)	(5.820)	(6.508)	(8.026)	(8.026)
Mean	678	637	636	631	631
Close election #	29	39	45	55	56
Observations	2321	4190	4328	4718	4723
Panel C	White				
	All tracts				
Bandwidth	0.06	0.08	0.10	0.12	0.14
PostXBlackwin	17.83**	28.55***	27.78***	23.95***	23.87***
	(7.124)	(4.157)	(4.163)	(5.125)	(5.141)
Mean	999	997	995	995	994
Close election #	29	39	45	55	56
Observations	2321	4190	4328	4718	4723
FE: Year	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
FE: Election	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
FE: Tract	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

Notes: The dependent variable is tract-level net population change. Panel A reports results for all voters, Panel B for African American voters, and Panel C for white voters. Columns vary the close-election bandwidth while retaining the all-tract sample definition. Net population change is constructed as winsorized voter inflows minus winsorized voter outflows. All specifications include year, election, and tract fixed effects, with standard errors clustered at the city level. Significance levels are denoted by $^{*}p < 0.10$, $^{**}p < 0.05$, and $^{***}p < 0.01$.

A.3 The institutional background of voter registration data in North Carolina

North Carolina has a high voter registration rate. As of January 9, 2021, there were 7,186,435 registered voters in North Carolina, accounting for 67% of the stateÃfÂ¢Ã¢â€šÂ¬Ã¢â€žÂ¢s total population.

To register as a voter in North Carolina, several qualifications need to be met. Firstly, one must be a U.S. citizen, though it is worth noting that specific citizenship documents are not required during registration. Potential voters can refer to the USCIS website for more details on citizenship. Secondly, an individual must reside in the county where they are registering and must have lived there for at least 30 days before the election. While these rules apply to most, there are special provisions under the federal Uniformed and Overseas Citizens Absentee Voting Act (UOCAVA). This act grants special rights to active duty military members, their families, and U.S. citizens living abroad, offering them a streamlined process to register and vote via mail-in ballots. Age is also a determining factor; one must be 18 years or older on the date of the general election. However, North Carolina does permit 16- and 17-year-olds to preregister. Moreover, 17-year-olds are allowed to vote in primary elections if they will turn 18 by the general election. Finally, those currently serving a felony sentence, which includes probation, post-release supervision, or parole, are ineligible to register.

Voter registration snapshot files provide up-to-date details for active voters, inactive voters, and voters removed within the past decade in North Carolina. They also include those who have tried to register or have unfinished registration steps. If a voterÃfÂ¢Ã¢â€šÂ¬Ã¢â€žÂ¢s last voting date is over 10 years before the snapshot, they are excluded from these files, which are refreshed every Saturday. Post-election, finalizing voter registration might take several days across all counties. Voters are not removed from records for not voting. Instead, a biennial list maintenance process, as per federal and state laws, determines removals. After two federal election cycles without contact, voters receive a confirmation mailing, which they must return within 30 days. Failure to do so, or if the mail is undelivered, marks them as inactive. Although inactive voters remain registered, they need to confirm their address when voting. After another two federal election cycles without contact, they are removed from the rolls, necessitating re-registration. This process aligns with N.C.G.S Ãfâ€šÃ‚Â§ 163-82.14.